



CITY: Pg 3

Delhi's blueprint to beat the jam



NATION: Pg 7

Shah calls on Prez amid buzz of reshuffle of council of ministers



FILM: Pg 14

Samantha Ruth Prabhu confirms pregnancy

Senior IPS officer Mahesh Dixit named new IB chief



NEW DELHI: Senior IPS officer Mahesh Dixit has been appointed Director of the Intelligence Bureau (IB), India's premier domestic intelligence agency, at a time when the country faces evolving internal security challenges.

A 1993 batch IPS officer of the Telangana cadre, Dixit's appointment was approved by the Appointments Committee of the Cabinet. He takes over after the outgoing IB Director completes his tenure. Dixit brings decades of experience in intelligence gathering and internal security. He previously headed the IB's Subsidiary Intelligence Bureau in Srinagar, which oversees Jammu, Kashmir and Leh. Officials said he played a key role in maintaining internal stability and monitoring security threats in the period following the abrogation of Article 370. Over the years, Dixit has handled several sensitive assignments within the Intelligence Bureau. He is known for building a strong ground intelligence network and has extensive experience in counter-terror operations, Left Wing Extremism and

Continued on P4

No deal with the US without competitive tariff advantage: India

LONDON: Commerce and Industry Minister Piyush Goyal on Thursday said India and the United States are "very close" to concluding the first phase of their bilateral trade agreement, but made it clear that the pact will move forward only if India secures a tariff advantage over competing nations.

Speaking at the India Global Forum UK-India Week in London, Goyal said, "The day that happens, the deal is on." He added that a free trade agreement must give India better market access than rival exporting countries. "And until the framework of getting that competitive advantage can be finalised, we can't enter into force a US deal," he said, adding that both countries were working on identifying the legal and policy tools needed to achieve that objective. Goyal is on a three-day visit to the UK to

Continued on P4

Centre says passport never been citizenship proof; Oppn cries foul

GOVT ASSERTS NO NEW DECISION TAKEN IN PAST 12 YEARS

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: A political storm broke out on Thursday over the status of passports as proof of Indian citizenship, after remarks by Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) officials triggered sharp exchanges between the government and opposition parties.

While the Centre maintained that a passport has always been a travel document rather than conclusive proof of citizenship, opposition leaders accused the government of creating uncertainty around citizenship rights and voter eligibility. The controversy unfolded alongside a notification by the MEA increasing the fee for a fresh 36-page ordinary passport from Rs 1,500 to Rs 2,500, effective through a gazette notification dated June 20.

The row began after media reports quoted MEA officials as saying that a passport is a travel document and not a document that establishes citizenship. Responding to the reports, government sources said there was no policy shift and that the legal

EXPLAINED: WHAT ESTABLISHES CITIZENSHIP IN INDIA?

CITIZENSHIP: Legal status established through birth details, parents' status, and government records over time.

WHY COMMON IDs ARE NOT STANDALONE PROOF OF CITIZENSHIP: Passport: Strong evidence, but not conclusive proof; non-citizens can receive passports in exceptional cases under the Passports Act, 1967.

AADHAAR: Proof of identity and residence only; non-citizen residents can legally obtain it.

PAN CARD: Tax identification document, not citizenship proof.

VOTER ID: Shows inclusion in electoral rolls, but does not by itself conclusively establish citizenship in a legal dispute.

WHAT PROVES CITIZENSHIP? India has no single national citizenship card.

Citizenship is determined through a combination of documents based on the basis of the claim.

FIVE ROUTES TO INDIAN CITIZENSHIP:

By Birth

By Descent

By Incorporation of Territory

By Registration

By Naturalisation



position had remained unchanged for decades.

"It was not decided yesterday that the passport is not proof of citizenship. It was not even decided in the last 12 years under the Narendra Modi government. The passport has never been a proof of citizenship," a government source said.

The government cited provisions of the Passports Act, 1967,

to support its position. Officials pointed to Section 20 of the Act, which allows the central government to issue a passport or travel document to a person who is not an Indian citizen if it considers such action necessary in the public interest.

At the same time, Section 6(2) (a) of the Act states that passport authorities shall refuse to

issue a passport if the applicant is not a citizen of India. Government sources said the law makes a distinction between routine issuance of passports and exceptional cases covered under public interest provisions.

The ruling Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) defended the MEA's clarification, saying it merely restated a

Continued on P4

SIT books 8 in Ram Temple donation theft case

BISWAJEET BANERJEE

AYODHYA: The Shri Ram Janmabhoomi Teerth Kshetra Trust on Thursday lodged an FIR in connection with the alleged theft and irregularities involving donations at the Ram Temple in Ayodhya, days after a Special Investigation Team (SIT) submitted its preliminary findings to the Uttar Pradesh government.

The complaint, filed by trust

The complaint, filed by trust member Krishna Mohan on the basis of the SIT's initial report, names eight accused

member Krishna Mohan on the basis of the SIT's initial report, names eight accused. Notably, the

FIR does not include the name of trust general secretary Champat Rai, though his close associate Ramshankar Yadav, popularly known as Tinnu Yadav, has been named among the accused.

According to officials, the case has been registered under multiple provisions of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita, including Sections 306, 316(5), 317(4), 317(5), 61 and 3(5).

The development comes two days after the

Continued on P4

Govt proposes per-person 7 kg ration for AAY households

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Centre has proposed a major change in the foodgrain allocation system for beneficiaries of the Antyodaya Anna Yojana (AAY), a scheme aimed at supporting the poorest households in the country. The move seeks to link foodgrain entitlement to family size rather than providing a fixed quantity to every household.

The Department of Food and Public Distribution has proposed amendments to the National Food Security Act (NFSA), 2013, and the Ministry of Consumer Affairs, Food and Public Distribution has invited public comments on the National Food Security (Amendment) Bill, 2026. Stakeholders can submit their views until July 13.

Continued on P4

Centre restores commercial LPG supply to pre-crisis levels

Household LPG supply remains top priority as Centre plans wider shift of commercial users to PNG

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Centre on Thursday restored commercial liquefied petroleum gas (LPG) supplies to hotels, restaurants and other businesses to levels seen before the recent West Asia conflict, while easing restrictions introduced during the crisis as

domestic production improved and imported cargoes were expected to arrive.

In a statement, the Petroleum Ministry said all sector-specific restrictions on non-domestic packed LPG had been withdrawn after the LPG supply situation improved. The government also partially resumed bulk

LPG supplies, which had been completely suspended at the beginning of the crisis, allowing them to return to 50 per cent of pre-conflict consumption levels.

The latest decision marks a rollback of emergency measures introduced after the conflict in West Asia disrupted LPG shipments from the

region, which accounts for nearly 90 per cent of India's cooking gas imports. Concerned about possible shortages, the government had diverted available supplies to households by stopping commercial LPG supplies to hotels, restaurants and industrial users.

Commercial supplies were later restored in phases to

Continued on P4

Food, fuel and medicines dry up in POK amid Islamabad's crackdown

Pakistan accused of blocking essential supplies

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI/ISLAMABAD: Pakistan-occupied Kashmir (POK) is facing a worsening humanitarian and political crisis as anti-government protests continue to spread across Pakistan-occupied Kashmir. The unrest began over 12 reserved assembly seats for Kashmir refugees that are reserved for refugees from Indian-administered Kashmir. Local groups have accused Islamabad of using those seats to influence election outcomes and install governments favourable to the federal authorities. The controversy triggered a mass protest movement led by the Joint Awami Action Com-

KEY POINTS

- Anti-government protests continue to spread across Pakistan-occupied Kashmir
- Unrest began over 12 reserved assembly seats for Kashmir refugees
- Protesters accuse Islamabad of manipulating elections through reserved seats

mittee (JAAC), which Pakistan later designated as a terrorist organisation.

A subsequent crackdown on protesters and JAAC supporters has reportedly led to deadly clashes. According to reports, at least 58 people have been killed since the movement intensified.

The JAAC has organised a region-wide shutdown that has disrupted transport networks, halted the movement of goods and services, and forced businesses and markets to close. Protests, sit-ins and strikes have paralysed normal

Continued on P4



CARRING Minds INTERNATIONAL Institute of Mental Health

28/8 GARIAHAT ROAD, KOLKATA - 700029. (NEAR DHAKURIA BRIDGE)

TUESDAY TO SATURDAY: 10 AM - 7 PM SUNDAY: 11 AM - 6 PM

033 4950 0900

+91 79806 16653

www.carringmindsinternational.com

A PATTON GROUP INITIATIVE

BUREAUCRATIC REJIG

Delhi govt transfers 60 IAS & DANICS officers

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: In a major administrative reshuffle, the Delhi government has transferred 60 IAS and DANICS cadre officers, involving secretaries of four ministers, with immediate effect.

According to the Services department orders issued on Wednesday, the additional chief secretary (ACS) of the Social Welfare Department will also handle the additional charge of the Women and Child Development department.

Navin Chaudhary IAS (AGMUT 1994), ACS Irrigation Department, will take additional charge of the general administration department (GAD) after the relieving of Pandurang Pole (AGMUT 1994). Pole will now be Secretary (Land and Building) with additional charge of Secretary, Labour and Cooperation.

Sandeep Kumar Singh (AGMUT 2011), who is Special Secretary at the Chief Minister's Office (CMO), will also handle the charge of managing director of Shahjahanabad Redevelopment Corporation.

Sachin Rana (AGMUT 2014), holding the post of special secretary (Home), will hold

Min Pankaj Singh's secretary, Vaibhav Rikhari (DANICS 2013), was also transferred as director of DJB

additional charges of Special Secretary of Urban Development, and principal director of Delhi Fire Services. Santosh Kumar Rai will be the special CEO of Delhi Disaster Management Authority (DDMA) with additional charge of Special Secretary (Home).

Ankur Mehram (DANICS 2014), serving as ADM (Outer North), will now be the secretary to Social Welfare Minister Ravinder Singh Indraj.

Vinay Kumar Jindal (DANICS 2014), who served as secretary to Law Minister Kapil Mishra, will now be Delhi Jal Board (DJB) director. Ranjeet Kumar Singh (DANICS 2014), joint director (education), will replace him as the new secretary to Mishra.

Health Minister Pankaj Singh's secretary, Vaibhav Rikhari (DANICS 2013), was also transferred as director of DJB. Mukesh Rajora (DAN-

ICS 2013) ADM (HQ) will be the new secretary of Singh, who also holds the Transport and IT department charge.

Rajesh Chaudhary (DANICS 2013), serving as joint secretary (urban development, will be secretary to Industries and Environment minister Manjinder Singh Sirsa, according to the orders.

Several district magistrates and sub-divisional magistrates were also reshuffled in the administrative shake-up.

South West district magistrate Mekala Chaitanya Prasad (AGMUT 2015) will be Special Secretary (Health), while KK Lakshman (AGMUT 2017) has been shifted from Old Delhi district magistrate to the same post in South West Delhi.

East Delhi district magistrate Anmol Srivastava (AGMUT 2018) will now be special commissioner (Transport), according to the order.

Out of the total 60 officers whose postings were effected, 17 belonged to the Arunachal Pradesh, Goa, Mizoram, and Union Territories (AGMUT) cadre of IAS, and 43 were of Delhi, Andaman and Nicobar, Lakshadweep, Daman and Diu and Dadra and Nagar Haveli Civil Services (DANICS) cadre.

'We have nowhere to go': Yamuna Bazar residents struggle with homelessness after DDA demolition

NEW DELHI: Several families in the city's Yamuna Bazar area are torn between paying steep rents for a roof over their heads or moving into "unsafe" shelter homes after they were left homeless in a demolition drive.

Earlier in the day, the Delhi Development Authority (DDA) demolished several houses it found illegal in the Yamuna Bazar area near Kashmere Gate.

The authority said it had issued notices asking residents living in settlements between Ghat Nos 2 and 32 to vacate the protected Yamuna floodplain.

Carrying whatever belongings they could salvage, residents were seen leaving the area amid uncertainty over where they would move next. Some of them alleged that authorities did not let trucks or tempos enter the area to transport



their belongings.

Nagendra Mishra, a light technician in his 40s who works near Kashmere Gate and has lived in the area for nearly two decades, said his family does not want to move into a shelter home. "I have a family of eight people. They have asked us to shift to different night shelters. Those facilities are not safe for us. Our daughters don't feel safe there," Mishra said.

Some sobbed while others bottled their emotions as they

sat before their rubble-reduced houses. "We had a three-room house here. Now to find the same size space is going to cost us at least Rs 12,000-15,000 in the nearby areas, which are really congested," Mishra said, adding that the heat has made the situation worse.

Among those rendered homeless was Navin Bhandari, 50, whose father, Ram Chandra Bhandari, now in his 80s, had moved to the banks of the Yamuna from Bihar more

“My father came here when he was in his early twenties. My elder brother's family, my family and our parents have lived here for decades...”

than six decades ago. "My father came here when he was in his early twenties. My elder brother's family, my family and our parents have lived here for decades, now suddenly authorities have come and demolished the entire neighbourhood," Bhandari said.

A temple nearby where he used to work was also razed, he said.

Muskan, a third-year BA student who lives with her maternal uncle and aunt, feared

her studies may now end. "I lost my mother years ago, and then my father left. I have lived my whole life with my uncle and aunt. They have nurtured me. Now I will start looking for a job since I can't be a burden on them, and the rent is going to affect us all," she said.

Muskan said she is currently an intern at a Chartered Accountant firm in East Delhi, and plans to find a full-time job. According to the residents, at least 310 homes were demolished, rendering at least 1,100 people homeless.

On June 23, the DDA issued fresh notices asking residents to vacate the "illegal" settlements voluntarily.

The area comes under the Yamuna's O-Zone, a protected no-construction floodplain, according to the DDA.

Seelampur: 17-year-old boy stabbed to death

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Two juveniles have been apprehended for allegedly stabbing a 17-year-old boy to death in northeast Delhi's Seelampur following an altercation, police said on Thursday.

Police said the two juveniles, aged between 15 and 16 years, were apprehended

within hours of the incident, and efforts are underway to trace a third suspect.

The crime weapon, a knife, has been recovered while the motorcycle used by the accused has been impounded, they said.

The deceased, identified as Lucky Kumar, a resident of Gautampuri, sustained multiple stab wounds on his upper body. A PCR call regarding the

stabbing incident was received around 9 pm on Tuesday. When police reached the spot in Gautampuri, they found that Lucky had already been shifted to Jag Pravesh Chandra Hospital by his cousin, where doctors declared him dead.

A case of murder was registered at Seelampur police station in this connection. Police said the crime team and foren-

sic experts inspected the scene and collected evidence.

Investigators analysed CCTV footage from the area and developed technical and local intelligence, which helped identify the suspects. Police said the juveniles confessed to the murder following an earlier altercation with the victim, and identified a third accused who remains absconding.

Husband booked after woman dies by suicide in Nangloi

PRAJYOT DEOGHARE

NEW DELHI: A 26-year-old woman allegedly died by suicide after enduring repeated domestic violence at the hands of her husband, police said.

The incident came to light on June 23 when Nangloi Police received a PCR call at around 11.09 am informing them that the woman had been brought dead to Sanjay Gandhi Memorial Hospital.

As the death occurred within seven years of marriage, the case was referred to the Sub-Divisional Magistrate (SDM) for mandatory inquest proceedings in accordance with legal provisions.

During the inquiry, the Tehsildar of Mundka recorded the statement of the deceased's mother, who alleged that her son-in-law, identified as Rohit, regularly assaulted her daughter while under the influence of alcohol. Police said Rohit is currently undergoing treatment for a life-threatening head injury sustained in a road accident a few months ago.

According to his doctors, his condition remains critical and he is not expected to survive beyond two to three years.

The investigation gathered momentum after the deceased's family submitted two videos purportedly recorded by the woman before taking the extreme step. Police said the videos suggest she was suffering from severe psychological distress and feared for her life



“The deceased's mother alleged that her son-in-law, identified as Rohit, regularly assaulted her daughter while under the influence of alcohol...”

due to continuous harassment by her husband.

A post-mortem examination was conducted on June 24 to determine the exact cause of death.

Based on the statements of family members, findings of the preliminary inquiry and other material collected during the investigation, police have registered a case against the husband.

Investigators are examining the videos and other evidence to establish the circumstances that led to the woman's death. Further investigation is underway, and additional legal action will be taken based on the findings of the probe, police said.

Students & faculty flag impact of steep fee hikes at Delhi University

ANAMTA FATIMA

NEW DELHI: A steep rise in fees across several Certificate, Diploma, Postgraduate (PG), and Research programmes at Delhi University (DU) has sparked concern among students and faculty, with reports indicating a decline in admissions in multiple departments.

According to recent findings, fees for certain courses have increased by as much as 425 per cent over the past few years, significantly altering access to programmes that were once considered relatively affordable. The increase has particularly affected short-term academic programmes and specialised higher education courses.

Teachers and student groups have argued that the revised fee structure may disproportionately impact stu-



dents from economically weaker backgrounds, limiting access to higher education opportunities. They contend that affordability has historically been one of the factors attracting students to certificate and diploma programmes, and a sudden increase risks reducing participation.

Data cited in the report also points to a fall in application numbers and enrolments in select PG and research

courses. In some departments, seats reportedly remain vacant despite earlier trends of strong demand and competition for admission.

Education experts have highlighted the need to strike a balance between institutional requirements and inclusive access. They argue that while universities face increasing administrative, academic and infrastructure-related costs, fee revisions should be implemented in a manner that does not create barriers for prospective students.

Responding to concerns, DU administration has maintained that the updated fee structure was introduced after considering operational and academic needs. However, the issue continues to generate debate within academic circles and among student organisations.

Massive fire breaks out at Bandhwari landfill in Ggm

GURUGRAM: A massive fire broke out at the Bandhwari waste management site on Gurugram's Faridabad Road on Thursday, sending thick black smoke into the sky and triggering concerns over air pollution in nearby areas.

Fire brigade teams rushed to the spot after receiving information about the blaze. Eight fire tenders from Sector 29, Sohna and nearby fire stations were deployed to contain the flames. Officials said firefighting efforts were being hampered by smouldering gases trapped beneath heaps of garbage. Crews are using water jets, soil and Poclain machines to bring the fire under control and prevent it from spreading.

Residents reported breathing difficulties and eye irritation due to the dense smoke. The landfill receives nearly 2,400 metric tonnes of mixed waste daily.

Gr Noida: FIR filed over unrest during GIMS workers' protest

GREATER NOIDA: Police have registered an FIR over alleged violence, disruption of medical services and damage to government property during an ongoing protest by outsourced employees at the Government Institute of Medical Sciences (GIMS) in Greater Noida, officials said on Thursday.

The case was registered on the complaint of GIMS Director Brig (Dr) Rakesh Gupta. Outsourced employees have been staging an indefinite pro-

test since June 15, demanding regularisation of their services.

According to police, the administration repeatedly urged protesters on Wednesday to shift their demonstration away from the hospital's main entrance and hall to ensure uninterrupted medical services.

However, some protesters allegedly refused and became aggressive. Police claimed that outsiders and members of various organisations were also called to the site and allegedly

threatened staff, used abusive language and attempted to force open a gate.

Officials said the incident disrupted patient care, including treatment of critically ill patients. Based on Gupta's complaint, an FIR was registered under relevant provisions. Gupta denied allegations of a police lathi-charge, while police said outpatient and other medical services were functioning normally after some protesters and outside supporters left the premises.



the office where the fire originated was closed at the time of the incident, and the individual initially believed to be inside had safely exited the building before emergency teams arrived.

"Firefighters carried out a sustained operation and managed to bring the blaze under control without any injuries or casualties," Kumar said.

Visuals from the site showed thick smoke billow-

ing from the upper floors of the tower as firefighting teams worked to prevent the flames from spreading to adjoining offices.

Golden I is a mixed-use commercial hub in Tech Zone-4, housing offices, retail outlets, restaurants and other commercial establishments.

Preliminary findings indicate that the fire may have been caused by a short circuit, although officials said the exact cause would be determined after a detailed investigation.

"The fire has been completely extinguished and an inquiry has been initiated," Kumar added.

Authorities said there was no structural damage to the building beyond the affected office area. Normal operations at the complex are expected to resume once safety inspections are completed.

Woman talking to man late at night no ground to question her character: Court

NEW DELHI: A Delhi court has observed that a woman speaking to a man over the phone at late hours cannot, by itself, be a ground to question her character or justify intrusion into her privacy through preservation of her call detail records (CDRs).

Additional Sessions Judge Shunali Gupta made the observation while dismissing an appeal filed by a man against a trial court order rejecting his plea to preserve the CDRs of his wife and another person in a pending domestic violence case. In its order, the court said that talking to any person, even at odd hours, cannot cast doubt on a woman's character unless there are specific allegations of an illegal or adulterous relationship. The husband had argued that the records were required because his wife was allegedly in regular late-night contact with certain individuals and the data could be deleted over time.

Upholding the trial court's decision, the judge said requests for preservation of call records must be backed by specific and reasonable grounds. Stressing that women work alongside male colleagues across sectors, the court held that any invasion of privacy must be justified and dismissed the appeal.



ABVP's Delhi University unit organised a seminar titled "Memories of the Emergency and Delhi University" at Kirori Mal College to mark the 51st anniversary of the Emergency

Although every possible care and caution has been taken to avoid errors or omissions, this publication is being sold on the condition and understanding that information given in this publication is merely for reference and must not be taken as having authority of or binding in any way on the writers, editors, publishers, and printers and sellers who do not owe any responsibility for any damage or loss to any person, a purchaser of this publication or not for the result of any action taken on the basis of this work. All disputes are subject to the exclusive jurisdiction of competent court and forums in Delhi/New Delhi only

Printed and Published by Jaiyendra Kumar Sharma on behalf of Front Row Media Pvt. Ltd. and printed at The Indian Express Pvt. Ltd., A-8, Sector-7, Noida-201 301 (U.P.) and published from First Floor, Pratap Bhawan, 5 Bahadur Shah Zafar Marg, New Delhi 110 002. Editor: Durbar Ganguly. Email: editor@millenniumpost.in, Tel. No. 011-47777500, Kolkata office: Room No 1, 15th Floor, Chatterjee International Centre, 33A Jawaharlal Nehru Road, Kolkata 700071 West Bengal, Siliguri Office: Techno India Group Zonal Office G-212, 2nd Floor Office Block - City Centre Matigara District Darjeeling Pin - 734010 Phone- 0353- 2576321

Delhi’s blueprint to beat the jam

PLAN TARGETS 62 HOTSPOTS WITH ROAD WIDENING, FLYOVERS...

AIMAN FATIMA

NEW DELHI: For lakhs of Delhi commuters stuck in daily traffic snarls, the Delhi Traffic Police has prepared an extensive decongestion plan targeting 62 traffic hotspots across the Capital, including 10 locations identified as the most critical bottlenecks. The plan proposes a mix of immediate enforcement, engineering interventions and long-term infrastructure projects to ease congestion over the coming months.

According to a report reviewed by *Millennium Post*, few of the worst congestion points are Ashram Chowk, Jaitpur Mor, Mathura Road near Okhla, Bawana Chowk, MB Road, Kondli Bridge, ISBT Anand Vihar, Shadipur Chowk, Azadpur Mandi, AIIMS-Safdarjung Corridor, Moolchand Flyover Junction, and Bhaira Enclave.

Officials said the city’s traffic woes are being driven by multiple factors. “Narrow carriageways, bottlenecks, damaged road markings, inadequate U-turns, ongoing construction works, encroachments, poor drainage and waterlogging are among the key infrastructure-related causes of congestion,” the report noted. It further stated that “illegal parking, poor lane discipline, unauthorised roadside occupation, weekly markets, school traffic and festival-related rush add to the problem.”



REPRESENTATIONAL IMAGE

To address these issues, authorities have proposed immediate measures within 30 days, including deployment of additional traffic personnel during peak hours, strict enforcement against illegal parking, wrong-side driving and encroachments, pothole repairs and repainting of lane markings, zebra crossings and stop lines.

The report details location-specific problems and solutions. At Kondli Bridge, where 11 roads converge near four government schools and a crematorium ground, heavy pedestrian and vehicular movement causes severe congestion. Authorities

have suggested constructing a subway or foot overbridge and exploring staggered school timings.

At ISBT Anand Vihar, officials said the convergence of the ISBT, railway station, Metro station and RRTS corridor generates massive passenger footfall, while auto-rickshaws and buses often occupy road space outside the terminal. “Roadside encroachments need to be removed and auto stands regulated, while DTC buses should be directed to pick up and drop passengers inside the terminal to prevent spillover congestion,” an official said.

At Azadpur Chowk, heavy

DECONGESTION DRIVE

» According to a report reviewed by *Millennium Post*, few of the worst congestion points are Ashram Chowk, Jaitpur Mor, Mathura Road near Okhla, Bawana Chowk, MB Road, Kondli Bridge, ISBT Anand Vihar, Shadipur Chowk, Azadpur Mandi, AIIMS-Safdarjung Corridor, Moolchand Flyover Junction, & Bhaira Enclave

» Officials said the city’s traffic woes are being driven by multiple factors

» ‘Narrow carriageways, bottlenecks, damaged road markings, inadequate U-turns, ongoing construction works, encroachments, poor drainage and waterlogging are among the key infra-related causes of congestion’

» It further stated that ‘illegal parking, poor lane discipline, unauthorised roadside occupation, weekly markets, school traffic and festival-related rush add to the problem’

» Authorities have proposed immediate measures within 30 days

movement of trucks and commercial vehicles linked to Azadpur Mandi creates daily traffic jams. The proposed solution is an elevated corridor or flyover.

Ashram Chowk, one of Delhi’s busiest intersections, suffers from excessive traffic volume. Traffic Police have proposed a subway to improve traffic flow, while Mathura Road near Okhla Mode faces congestion due to merging traffic from Mathura Road and the Modi Mill Flyover, requiring engineering redesign of the junction.

In South Delhi, IGNOU Road, Khanpur, Chirag Delhi and Adchini are facing congestion due to Metro construction,

narrow roads, temporary bus stands and weekly markets. Officials have proposed road widening, relocation of bus stops, shifting weekly markets and construction of subways or foot overbridges.

At Kalindi Kunj, officials pointed out that “six lanes of traffic arriving from Noida are forced into three lanes inside Delhi, creating a severe bottleneck. Engineering redesign of the corridor has been proposed.”

At Bawana Chowk, narrow roads, educational institutions and encroachments create bottlenecks. Road widening, pedestrian zones and improved public transport have been rec-

ommended. Similarly, at Bhaira Enclave, ongoing metro construction and heavy traffic volumes have prompted recommendations for an elevated corridor or flyover.

The report also highlights several market-driven congestion points, including Sadar Bazar, South Extension, Gandhi Nagar, Durgapuri, Najafgarh and Uttam Nagar, where roadside parking, hawkers, vendors and heavy pedestrian movement occupy valuable road space. Solutions include dedicated pedestrian zones, anti-encroachment drives, parking facilities, relocation of weekly markets and construction of subways and foot overbridges.

For medium-term implementation, authorities have proposed traffic islands, signal optimisation, relocation of bus stops and auto stands, and installation of signages and reflectors. Long-term recommendations include road widening, flyovers, service lanes, smart traffic systems, dedicated bus lanes and infrastructure to prevent jaywalking.

“Each hotspot will be reviewed weekly by a joint task force, with progress documented through photographs and videos,” officials said. The Traffic Police has also sought support from PWD, MCD, DMRC, NHAI and the Transport Department to ensure the proposed interventions are implemented in a coordinated manner.

CM SHRI boost

Delhi govt okays Rs 265 crore upgrade plan for 75 schools

AIMAN FATIMA

NEW DELHI: In a major push to modernise government school infrastructure, the Delhi government has approved a Rs 264.90-crore proposal for the comprehensive upgradation of 75 CM SHRI schools across the Capital. The project, cleared by the Expenditure Finance Committee (EFC) chaired by Chief Minister Rekha Gupta, aims to transform school campuses with improved safety measures, modern facilities, sports infrastructure and technology-enabled learning spaces.

Announcing the decision, Chief Minister Rekha Gupta said the initiative goes beyond routine repairs and seeks to create a better educational environment for students. “Our objective is not merely to repair school buildings, but to create a learning environment where students have access to safe, clean, modern and inspiring campuses,” she said.

According to the government, the project will include waterproofing and seepage treatment, interior and exterior painting, repairs to boundary walls, upgrades to toilets and drinking water facilities, improvements in drainage and sewerage systems, renovation of multipurpose halls, and development of sports infrastructure wherever required.

Electrical upgrades will focus on safety and modernisation. Defective LED lights, fans and public address systems



will be replaced, while high-mast lighting, CCTV surveillance systems, air-conditioning in computer labs and multipurpose halls, stage lighting, LED signage, RO water coolers, upgraded electrical panels and additional LAN points will be installed.

Special emphasis has also been placed on accessibility for children with special needs. Schools will be equipped with ramps, tactile pathways and handrails to ensure an inclusive learning environment.

Highlighting the scale of the transformation, Gupta said, “The project will completely transform the appearance of school campuses. Modern CM SHRI entrance gates will be developed and outdoor galleries will be created as spaces for learning, recreation and collaborative activities.”

The government plans to redesign school entrances with CM SHRI branding, beautify campuses, upgrade sports grounds and lay new turf on basketball courts. The works are targeted for completion by the end of next year.



City’s cyber shield

OUR CIRRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: As cyber threats grow more sophisticated and increasingly targeted government systems, the Delhi government on Thursday stepped up efforts to strengthen its digital security architecture, bringing together officials and cyber security experts to formulate a robust framework for protecting sensitive government data and critical digital infrastructure.

A state-level consultative workshop on strengthening cyber security frameworks for state data was organised at the Delhi Secretariat by the Information Technology Department, Government of NCT of Delhi, in collaboration with the National e-Governance Division (NeGD) under the Ministry of Electronics and Information Technology (MeitY). The workshop was inaugurated by Delhi’s Health, Transport and Information Technology Minister Dr. Pankaj Kumar Singh, who underscored the importance of cyber resilience in an era of rapid digitalisation.

Addressing participants, Dr. Singh said, “In today’s digital era, securing government data is not merely a technological responsibility but a commitment towards every citizen. Guided by the vision of Hon’ble Chief Minister Smt. Rekha Gupta for a digitally empowered and transparent Delhi, we are continuously strengthening our cyber security architecture

to safeguard government data and public digital services.”

He added, “As cyber threats continue to evolve, we must remain alert, enhance our cyber resilience and adopt future-ready systems to ensure secure and trusted digital governance.”

The minister said data security has become one of the government’s foremost priorities, noting that cyber criminals are employing increasingly sophisticated methods that transcend geographical boundaries. He stressed that securing sensitive government information is essential for ensuring uninterrupted public service delivery and maintaining citizens’ trust in digital governance.

Dr. Singh also urged all government departments to adopt best cyber security practices and promote a culture of cyber awareness across institutions. He appreciated the IT Department for organising the workshop and suggested that similar programmes be conducted over longer durations to provide officials with greater practical exposure to emerging cyber security challenges.

The workshop featured expert sessions on cyber threat intelligence, critical information infrastructure protection, incident response, data privacy, emerging technologies and global best practices in cyber risk management. Officials also discussed cyber governance, security audits, capacity building and awareness initiatives.

Government holds anti-drug awareness drive at India Gate

OUR CIRRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Marking the International Day Against Drug Abuse and Illicit Trafficking, the Delhi Government on Thursday organised a large-scale awareness programme at India Gate under the Nasha Mukti Bharat Abhiyan, with Social Welfare Minister Ravinder Indraj Singh leading citizens in taking a pledge for a drug-free Delhi and a drug-free India.

The event saw participation from MPs Manoj Tiwari and Bansuri Swaraj, senior government officials, representatives of social organisations, students, youth groups and citizens. A public awareness rally, anti-drug exhibition and cultural performances were also organised to spread awareness about the dangers of substance abuse.

Addressing the gathering, Ravinder Indraj Singh said, “The Central Government and the Delhi Government are working together towards building a Drug-Free India. Every citizen must join this fight against substance abuse. Public participation is the strongest pillar in achieving this national mission.”

The minister said drug addiction affects not only individuals but also families, communities and society at large. He stressed that growing vulnerability among young people towards substance abuse has emerged as a serious social challenge requiring collective action.

Highlighting ongoing efforts, Singh said the Ministry of Social Justice and Empowerment is implementing the Nasha Mukti Bharat Abhiyan and the National Action Plan for Drug Demand Reduction, focusing on awareness, counselling, treatment and rehabilitation.

Sanjay Lake: L-G reviews, 5K trees to take root

SHIVANGI SHUKLA

NEW DELHI: Delhi Lieutenant Governor TS Sandhu on Thursday visited Sanjay Lake in East Delhi to review the ongoing restoration and rejuvenation works being undertaken by the Delhi Development Authority (DDA) to revive the prominent recreational park.

During the inspection, DDA officials led by the Vice Chairman briefed the L-G on the phased action plan for rejuvenating the 52 acre manmade lake and the surrounding 165 acre protected forest area. Taking note of the disrupted water supply to the lake, the L-G directed authorities to expedite the repair of the pipeline to ensure a steady supply of



treated water from the Dallu-pura Sewage Treatment Plant (STP). Emphasized on treated water supply must be restored at the earliest to maintain optimal water levels and ensure the survival of Sanjay Lake as a weather bluegreen asset.

Reviewing ongoing interventions already undertaken following his earlier directions,

the L-G assessed continuous de-weeding and algae removal operations, strengthening of embankment slopes through geo-textile application to prevent excessive runoff and soil erosion, and repairs of damaged portions of the boundary wall. He directed officials to ensure these maintenance works are carried out meticulously and without delays.

Officials also briefed the L-G on Phase-I works, proposed to be completed by August 2026, which include channelisation of stagnant water into the water body at multiple stagnation points, installation of bioswales in low-lying areas to protect walking pathways and improve ground-water recharge, repair of pathways and routine maintenance work, and removal of lakebed grass. The L-G reviewed these measures aimed at improving water management and restoring the lake ecosystem. Reviewing the longterm roadmap, the L-G evaluated Phase-II works proposed for completion by May 2027. These include expanding the scope of

channelization of surrounding water into the lake, increasing the number of bio-swales to protect pathways and prevent water stagnation, undertaking bio-remediation of the water body to improve its physical and chemical characteristics, and installing aerators and fountains to improve dissolved oxygen levels and aesthetics.

He directed the plantation of 5,000 native trees to enrich biodiversity and reiterated that restoring Sanjay Lake to its former glory remains non-negotiable. He said these efforts would help transform the lake into a clean, vibrant and ecologically rich public space while strengthening Delhi’s environmental sustainability and resilience for future generations.

Golf Links Gets ‘ANUPAM’ tag

ANAMTA FATIMA

NEW DELHI: The New Delhi Municipal Council (NDMC) on Thursday designated Golf Links as its ninth “Anupam Colony”, recognising the residential area for its achievements in waste management and community sustainability practices under the civic body’s zero-waste and sustainable development campaign.

The certification was announced by NDMC Chairperson Keshav Chandra during the unveiling of a commemorative plaque at Golf Links. The recognition is awarded to residential communities that adopt scientific waste management systems and demonstrate sustained environmental responsibility. Addressing residents at the event, Chandra said the

achievement reflected a collective commitment towards environmentally responsible living and sustainable urban practices. He noted that the colony had effectively implemented waste segregation at source, enabling recyclable material to be channelled to appropriate recycling facilities while converting wet waste into compost for local horticultural use. According to NDMC, the initiative is intended to encourage self-sustaining residential communities through decentralised waste management and stronger public participation. Officials said the Golf Links model could serve as an example for other neighbourhoods across the Capital. Representatives of the Golf Links Association credited the certification to coordinated efforts by residents and local groups.

Focus on civic fixes

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD) House on Thursday held extensive deliberations on sanitation, waterlogging preparedness and civic infrastructure, with several public welfare proposals receiving approval during the session chaired by Mayor Pravesh Wahi.

According to the Mayor’s Office, councillors from both the ruling side and the opposition participated in the proceedings and raised concerns related to local governance and civic services. Discussions focused on sanitation management, desilting of drains, strengthening drainage systems and measures to minimise disruption during the upcoming monsoon season.

Addressing the House, Wahi said all councillors were given an opportunity to present concerns and recommendations from their respective wards, particularly on the issue of water-logging. He said the objective was to ensure inclusive participation in decision-making and develop practical solutions to issues affecting residents. The Mayor stated that the civic body, under the leadership of Chief Minister Rekha Gupta, is undertaking measures on a priority basis to address monsoon-related challenges. These include drain desilting, infrastructure strengthening and monitoring of locations identified as vulnerable to water accumulation.

He added that modern equipment and technology are being deployed to improve preparedness and reduce inconvenience to residents during the rainy season.

Ggm: Two men drown while bathing in a pond

GURUGRAM: Two men drowned in a pond in Gurugram, with one of losing his life while trying to rescue the other after he slipped into deep water, police said on Thursday.

The deceased were identified as Ranjeet Rai (48), a resident of Vaishali district in Bihar, and Mahendra Pal (34), a resident of Delhi’s Bijwasan area. Both worked at a timber warehouse in Gurugram.

According to a preliminary investigation, the two men

went to a pond in Bajghera village on Wednesday afternoon and entered the water to bathe after spending some time on its bank.

Police said Mahendra Pal allegedly slipped into a deeper section of the pond and began drowning. Rai, who had already come out of the water, jumped back in to rescue him.

As neither of them knew how to swim, both got trapped in the deep water and drowned, the police said.

AGENCIES

Crash triggers 4-km snarl

WISHAP NEAR JHARSA CHOWK LED TO LONG QUEUES

OUR CORRESPONDENT

GURUGRAM: A speeding Endeavour broke down and rammed into a car near Jharsa Chowk on Thursday, causing chaos and a 4-kilometre-long vehicle queue on the Delhi-Gurugram expressway, police said. According to eyewitnesses, the accident occurred around 1:30 pm when a white Endeavour lost control after a sudden breakdown and collided with a

Tata Magic moving ahead of it.

The impact damaged the Endeavour’s front section. The damaged car stopped in the middle of the road, disrupting traffic on the busy expressway, they said. Police said the car’s airbags prevented any major casualties; however, within minutes, hundreds of vehicles were caught in congestion, leaving commuters stuck for an hour until the Gurugram traffic police brought the situation under

control. After nearly an hour of effort, officials said a crane removed the damaged vehicle from the expressway to ensure smooth traffic flow.

“The accident occurred because the SUV suddenly broke down. Our traffic police team reached the spot immediately, but removing the damaged vehicle from the road took some time, which caused traffic congestion,” said Inspector Manoj Kumar, SHO Traffic-II.

From Page 1

Oppn cries foul

long-standing legal position. The party referred to the Citizenship Act, 1955, arguing that citizenship is determined under that law and not through possession of any single document. BJP leaders also cited judicial rulings, including a 2013 Bombay High Court judgment, which they said made it clear that a passport by itself is not proof of citizenship.

BJP IT department head Amit Malviya criticised opposition parties, accusing them of turning a settled legal issue into a political controversy.

Opposition leaders, however, questioned the implications of the government's position. Congress general secretary (organisation) K C Venugopal alleged that the ruling dispensation was creating conditions that could allow arbitrary decisions on citizenship.

“This government excels in creating panic and helplessness among ordinary citizens. By declaring that even a passport doesn't certify one's citizenship, they are laying the groundwork to arbitrarily deny citizenship rights to Indians who they disagree with,” Venugopal said in a post on X.

The debate quickly widened, drawing reactions from several opposition figures and public personalities.

Trinamool Congress leader Mahua Moitra remarked on X, “It would seem that the only proof of Indian citizenship today is to be both Hindu and a BJP voter. Nothing else will do.”

AIMIM president and Hyderabad MP Asaduddin Owaisi asked what documents citizens would need to establish nationality if passports, birth certificates, Aadhaar cards and voter identity cards were not considered proof of citizenship. “According to the govt, no document is conclusive proof of citizenship. By 2030, only one document will be proof of citizenship: BJP membership,” he said.

Rajya Sabha member Kapil Sibal also questioned the government's position, asking, “Which document then is proof of citizenship? BLO can doubt my citizenship. Deprive me of my vote. Result: BJP wins the election. Over to Supreme Court!”

Lyricist and former MP Javed Akhtar described the clarification as “absurd”, questioning whether passports could be issued without authorities being satisfied that the holder was an Indian citizen.

Amid the political exchanges, Election Commission officials sought to clarify that there has been no change in electoral procedures. Officials said Indian passports continue to be among the 12 supporting documents accepted for establishing eligibility during electoral roll verification exercises, including the ongoing Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls.

According to election officials, passports were accepted during the Bihar SIR exercise, earlier revisions in Assam and subsequent voter list revision programmes. “Passport was and continues to be one of the documents to establish identity,” an official said, adding that electoral registration officers examine submitted documents before deciding a person's eligibility to be included in voter rolls.

The issue also revived discussion around the distinction between identity documents and proof of citizenship. During recent hearings related to the Election Commission's electoral roll revision exercise, the Supreme Court observed that Aadhaar is not conclusive proof of citizenship and serves primarily as an identity document.

Government sources also referred to a Press Information Bureau clarification issued on December 20, 2019, in the form of frequently asked questions on the National Register of Citizens (NRC) and the Citizenship Amendment Act (CAA). The document stated that citizenship can be proved through documents relating to date and place of birth, although a final decision on acceptable documents had not been taken at the time.

The PIB clarification further stated that citizenship is determined under the Citizenship Rules, 2009, framed under the

Citizenship Act, 1955. It outlined five routes through which a person may become an Indian citizen: by birth, descent, registration, naturalisation and incorporation of territory.

As the controversy continued through the day, the government maintained that there had been no change in law or policy regarding passports, while opposition parties insisted that the clarification had raised broader concerns about citizenship documentation and voting rights.

A total of 14.7 million e-passports have been issued since the chip-based documents were rolled out last year as part of a revamp of the Passport Seva Programme, officials said.

Twin powerful

missing among collapsed buildings and toppled electric poles.

Acting President Delcy Rodríguez, who gave the latest death toll early Thursday, said that authorities were shifting rescue teams from other parts of the country to La Guaira, which sits north of Caracas on the coast. Officials were trying to make the most of the daylight hours to speed up efforts to rescue people believed to remain trapped under the rubble, she said.

Footage on state TV showed three children, covered in dust but alive, pulled from the rubble in La Guaira state, which Rodríguez described as a “disaster zone” and one of the areas hardest hit by the quakes because of the large number of collapsed buildings.

“Dozens of buildings have collapsed there ... and we are currently carrying out intensive rescue operations to save lives,” Rodríguez said.

Video shared online appeared to show dozens of people, some lying on the ground and others on hospital beds, being treated outside a hospital in La Guaira.

While Venezuela sits near multiple fault lines, its position straddling the South American and Caribbean plates makes strong earthquakes much less common than in other parts of Latin America.

Rodríguez appealed to businesses to make heavy construction equipment available for rescue operations, adding that search and rescue teams certified by the United Nations were on their way to Venezuela.

During the quakes, people ran from swaying buildings in Caracas, many visibly shocked when they turned back to see destroyed walls that left furniture visible from the street. Columns of dust rose in two typically busy neighborhoods in the capital.

“It started off gently and then gradually grew, and in the end, we all had to leave our houses, go outside and gather together,” Caracas resident Hector Ricci said.

The U.S. Geological Survey said the first earthquake, with a magnitude of 7.2, hit west of Moron on the Caribbean coast, about 170 kilometers (105 miles) west of Caracas. It had a depth of 22 kilometers (about 14 miles). Just a minute later, USGS reported a second 7.5 magnitude earthquake, with a depth of 10 kilometers (about 6 miles) and an epicenter 16 kilometers (10 miles) southwest of Moron.

Interior Minister Diosdado Cabello urged people to remain outside as aftershocks could further damage structures, and many people stayed on the streets for hours, some sitting on the ground hugging pets as dust gathered around them. In downtown Caracas, hundreds of people spent the night huddled around parks, parking lots and other open spaces. Authorities warned against returning to homes with structural damage.

“We were afraid the buildings would collapse on us,” said María Cristina Díaz, a 41-year-old janitor. “My mother, my daughter and I were cold. We didn't sleep a wink; but I didn't want to spend the night alone at home after that terrible earthquake.”

“It was awful. We cried, we screamed. Thankfully, we're alive,” she added.

Díaz and her family rushed to Plaza Candelaria in downtown Caracas because it's one of the few open areas near her home.

Parts of the capital lost power and cellphone coverage, and the earthquakes damaged and closed Simón Bolívar International Airport, the country's main airport, Rodríguez said.

In Caracas, subway services were suspended and natural gas shut off, she said. Classes will also be cancelled for several days, and the Ministry of Education said some school buildings would be used as shelters and donation centers.

On Thursday morning, scores of people in Venezuela and abroad struggled to contact family members. Families began posting missing-person fliers with photos of loved ones, while others shared handwritten lists of names as they searched for those still unaccounted for.

Also on Thursday, the UN human rights mission in Venezuela called on the government to lift local restrictions on social media.

“In the coming hours and days, timely access to reliable information and communication channels will be essential for the protection of the lives, safety, and well-being of the population,” the mission said in a statement.

In August 2024, then President Nicolás Maduro ordered X blocked in an attempt to suppress the exchange of information among those who rejected his claim of victory in the July presidential elections.

Rodríguez declared a state of emergency in an address to the nation late Wednesday. She said the government was creating a USD 200 million reconstruction fund for hospitals and homes damaged by the earthquakes, and had instructed the economy and finance ministers to oversee the effort.

Offers of help poured in from countries around the world.

US Secretary of State Marco Rubio said the United States is “immediately deploying search and rescue teams, medical resources, and humanitarian assistance to Venezuela.”

“We will have a whole government response,” Rubio said Thursday in Bahrain. “It will be big. It will be fast. It will be effective.”

He added that one of the runways at Caracas' international airport was cracked in the earthquake, making landing aircraft there difficult.

Rodríguez — who became acting president after an American military operation captured her predecessor, Nicolás and brought him to the US to stand trial — thanked US President Donald Trump. She said in an X post later that she spoke with Rubio by phone without sharing details. She also expressed thanks to the leaders of various nations who have sent messages of support and offers of help.

Ecuador ordered the delivery of humanitarian aid, and Rodríguez said Qatar, Mexico and El Salvador had already sent rescue personnel.

“We send you all our solidarity and our prayers. Stay strong, Venezuela,” El Salvador President Nayib Bukele, once diametrically opposed to Venezuela's government, wrote in a post on X.

NCERT introduces

It notes that growing public dissatisfaction with the government led by then-Prime Minister Indira Gandhi in the early 1970s was driven by rising unemployment, inflation, and allegations of misgovernance, leading to widespread protests.

The textbook states that a National Emergency was imposed in June 1975 on the grounds of internal disturbance. According to the text, most fundamental rights were suspended during the period, the press faced censorship and several political leaders and activists were arrested. It adds that democratic institutions came under severe strain and citizens' freedoms were restricted.

The Emergency was declared following a period of political unrest and a court verdict that set aside Gandhi's election.

Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan welcomed the inclusion of the chapter, saying NCERT had taken the right step. “Future generations should know and understand the dark deeds of the Emergency so that such a situation does not arise again,” he told reporters.

The BJP also supported the decision, calling the Emergency a “dark chapter” in India's constitutional history. Party spokesperson Shehzad Poonawalla alleged that constitutional institutions, including Parliament, the judiciary and the media, were targeted during the period.

He claimed that fundamental rights were suspended, judicial review was curtailed and constitutional safeguards were weakened.

Referring to singer Kishore Kumar, Poonawalla alleged that even his songs were removed from All India Radio during the Emergency. He said the chapter would help students understand the period and prevent similar developments in the future. He also questioned opposition to the textbook revision and referred to leaders such as Jayaprakash Narayan, Mulayam Singh Yadav and Lalu Prasad Yadav, who had opposed the Emergency.

The teaching of the Emergency has long been debated. While the topic was added to the Class 12 curriculum in 2007 during the UPA government, concerns were raised over whether textbooks fully reflected the period. In 2023, some content related to controversies surrounding the Emergency and alleged abuses of power was removed during a curriculum rationalisation exercise after the COVID-19 pandemic.

In 2018, then HRD Minister Prakash Javadekar had said the “whole story” of the Emergency should be included in school curricula so students could understand the realities of that period.

PM Modi says

The prime minister said India prays for the speedy recovery of those injured and stand in solidarity with all those affected during this difficult time. “India stands ready to extend all possible assistance,” he added.

AAY households

At present, every AAY household receives 35 kilograms of foodgrains each month, irrespective of the number of family members. In contrast, beneficiaries classified as Priority Households receive 5 kilograms of foodgrains per person every month.

According to the government, the existing arrangement has created disparities among beneficiaries. Large AAY families often receive less foodgrain on a per-person basis than members of Priority Households, despite AAY being intended for the most vulnerable sections of society.

“The existing household-based entitlement under Antyodaya Anna Yojana, though intended as a protective measure for the most vulnerable families, results in significant inequities depending upon the size of the household,” the ministry said.

Under the proposed amendment, AAY beneficiaries would receive 7 kilograms of foodgrains per person per month, subject to a maximum limit of 35 kilograms per household. As a result, a two-member family would be entitled to 14 kilograms a month, while households with five or more members would continue to receive the existing ceiling of 35 kilograms.

The government said the proposal is part of a broader effort to strengthen food and nutritional security through a “human life cycle approach”, aimed at ensuring access to adequate quantities of quality food at affordable prices in line with the objectives of the NFSA.

Rice and wheat are currently distributed free of cost to both Priority Households and AAY beneficiaries.

SIT books 8 in Ram Temple

three-member SIT submitted its preliminary report to the state government. The report was handed over by Lucknow Divisional Commissioner Vijay Vishwas Pant to additional Chief Secretary (Home) Sanjay Prasad after an inquiry into allegations of theft and financial irregularities related to temple donations.

Sources familiar with the probe had earlier indicated that the SIT's findings had raised questions over the roles of several individuals linked to the temple administration, including Champat Rai, trustee Dr Anil Mishra and construction in-charge Gopal Rao. A total of 17 people were reportedly identified during the investigation,

and FIRs against them were considered likely. However, none of these senior functionaries have been named in the FIR filed on Thursday.

During the investigation, SIT officials reportedly found that keys to several donation boxes were in the possession of Ramshankar Yadav alias Tinnu, a finding that became a significant part of the inquiry.

The SIT also scrutinised the financial profiles of nearly 150 temple employees and sevadars. Investigators flagged individuals whose economic conditions appeared to have changed substantially after the consecration ceremony of Ram Lalla on January 22, 2024, according to sources associated with the probe.

The controversy surfaced after allegations of theft of offerings and financial irregularities in the handling of donations made by devotees. Rejecting charges of wrongdoing, the Shri Ram Janmabhoomi Teerth Kshetra Trust had denied any financial misconduct and sought an impartial inquiry, following which the Uttar Pradesh government constituted the SIT.

As part of its investigation, the SIT questioned several individuals associated with the temple administration, including Champat Rai. The issue has since triggered a political storm, with opposition parties demanding transparency in the management of donations received by the temple.

The FIR marks the first formal criminal action arising from the SIT investigation and is expected to be followed by further questioning and scrutiny of financial records linked to the case.

LPG supply

around 70 per cent of normal levels, although several sectors continued to receive only half of their usual allocations as authorities sought to conserve stocks amid uncertainty over imports.

“In a major relief to industrial and commercial LPG consumers, the government has removed all sectoral restrictions on the supply of non-domestic packed LPG and restored supplies to the levels prevailing prior to the West Asia crisis,” the ministry said.

It added that “the supply of bulk LPG, which had been suspended at the onset of the crisis, has been relaxed by 50 per cent of the pre-crisis consumption levels, providing significant relief to commercial and industrial consumers.”

During the supply disruption, the government invoked provisions under the Essential Commodities Act to direct that C3 and C4 hydrocarbon streams be used exclusively for LPG production instead of petrochemicals and other industrial uses. The move required refiners, including Reliance Industries, to reduce petrochemical production in order to increase LPG output.

With supply conditions improving, authorities have decided to reduce the diversion of C3 and C4 streams to LPG production and restore larger allocations to petrochemical and other downstream industries. The ministry said this would be done while ensuring domestic LPG production remains above 40,000 tonnes per day.

“Taking note of the improved indigenous LPG production and the projected availability of imported LPG cargoes, the government has also decided to reduce the diversion of C3/C4 streams to the LPG pool,” the statement said.

The Centre of High Technology has been directed to issue organisation-wise allocations of the additional C3 and C4 streams for petrochemical and other critical sectors and submit regular reports to the ministry.

The ministry said uninterrupted LPG supplies to households would continue to receive the highest priority. It credited timely policy interventions and coordinated efforts by oil marketing companies for maintaining stable domestic supplies despite disruptions in global supply chains.

To strengthen supply planning, state-run oil marketing companies have been directed to maintain comprehensive databases of commercial and industrial LPG consumers. A unified sectoral database will also be created across the companies to improve monitoring and operational coordination.

The government also reiterated its plan to expand the use of piped natural gas (PNG). Commercial and bulk consumers already connected to PNG networks will continue using the fuel, while other eligible LPG consumers with access to city gas distribution networks will gradually be shifted to PNG.

The Secretary of the Ministry of Petroleum and Natural Gas has written to chief secretaries of all states and Union Territories to ensure smooth implementation of the revised supply arrangements.

The rollback comes as broader signs suggest the energy disruption triggered by the West Asia conflict is easing. Crude oil prices have returned to levels seen before the conflict, government crisis briefings have been discontinued, and shipping and energy flows have largely normalised, reducing concerns over fuel availability.

Mahesh Dixit

tackling cross-border infiltration. Officials believe his long experience in Jammu and Kashmir will help guide the agency's efforts against Pakistan-sponsored terrorism, radicalisation and narco-terror networks in his new role.

No deal with the US without

discuss implementation of the India-UK free trade agreement. Earlier this week, he held two days of talks in New Delhi with US Trade Representative Jamieson Greer on the proposed India-US bilateral trade agreement. However, the commerce ministry did not indicate whether all outstanding issues had been resolved before the temporary 10 per cent US tariff is due to expire on July 24.

The minister said the broad framework of the agreement had already been settled and announced on February 6, with negotiations now focused on finalising the finer details. “There is always a little give and take,” he said.

Goyal explained that when the framework was first agreed, Indian exports faced an 18 per cent US tariff while competing countries were subject to tariffs of 19 to 20 per cent, giving India a relative advantage. However, all countries are now subject to the same additional 10 per cent levy under the temporary tariff regime introduced by US President Donald Trump.

He said the focus of the ongoing negotiations is to ensure India secures lower effective tariffs than competitors such as Vietnam, Thailand, Malaysia, Indonesia, China, Bangladesh and Sri Lanka before the agreement is brought into force.

Islamabad's crackdown

life in several towns, while residents have also reported widespread mobile internet disruptions.

As the agitation enters another week, shortages of food, fuel and medicines have become increasingly visible. AFP reported that residents in Muzaffarabad, the regional capital, are struggling to obtain basic necessities. Sixty-four-year-old Muhammad Masqeen told the agency, “I have been searching for medicine everywhere, but I cannot find it. Even big stores are closed.”

Another resident, Sabar Hussain, said people had endured more than a week of hardship as markets remained shut and food supplies became increasingly scarce.

Fuel shortages have also worsened. According to Dawn, petrol pumps across the districts of Poonch and Muzaffarabad have remained closed, forcing some motorists to turn to the black market for fuel.

BBC Urdu reported that shortages of food, fuel and medicines have been particularly severe in the Poonch sector, including Rawalakot, as well as Bagh and the remote Neelum Valley. Residents say access to essential commodities has become increasingly difficult.

Alif Din, a resident of Neelum district, told BBC

Urdu that ration supplies had virtually stopped. “I have been depositing money at the depot for 15 days but have not received flour yet. I go to the depot every day, but I am not given flour,” he said, adding that flour prices in local markets had risen sharply.

Residents in Abbasur and Rawalakot told the outlet that food and medicine stockpiles built up by households were running low after grocery stores and pharmacies remained closed for nearly two weeks.

While part of the disruption is linked to the JAAC-led shutdown and road blockades, residents and opposition parties allege that Pakistani authorities have further aggravated the crisis by restricting the movement of essential supplies into the territory.

As shortages deepen, many residents have reportedly travelled into Pakistan to purchase necessities. According to Dawn, people from Muzaffarabad have crossed into neighbouring Khyber Pakhtunkhwa to buy food and fuel. BBC Urdu reported that residents from Poonch, Rawalakot, Bagh and Neelum Valley have travelled to Rawalpindi and Islamabad to purchase flour, rice, sugar, lentils, medicines and petrol.

However, several residents claim they have been prevented from bringing those goods back into POK. BBC Urdu reported that vehicles carrying food, medicines and fuel faced restrictions at checkpoints and roadblocks.

One resident, identified as Naveed, alleged that police stopped him near Azad Paltan and refused to allow him to proceed unless he discarded the supplies he had purchased in Rawalpindi. “I begged the police a lot to let me take food and drinks home for God's sake because the situation in my house has now reached the point of starvation. My wife is also pregnant,” he said. “But they did not care and said that if you throw away the food and drinks and medicines with your own hands, you are allowed to go, otherwise go back.”

Truck drivers have also reported difficulties. BBC Urdu said vehicles carrying flour, rice, lentils, vegetables and other essential commodities were being held at checkpoints near Azad Paltan and Phagwari. Drivers alleged that Punjab Police personnel prevented them from entering POK, leaving dozens of trucks stranded for days and causing perishable goods to spoil. Social media videos have also shown long queues of trucks reportedly waiting for permission to enter the region through various routes, including Mirpur.

The POK chapter of Pakistan Tehreek-e-Insaf (PTI) has accused authorities of blocking supplies and preventing travellers from carrying food, drinking water and life-saving medicines. The party described the reported actions as the “worst example of Pharaonic oppression”.

Pakistani officials, including police and district administrators in Muzaffarabad, Poonch and Neelum Valley, have rejected the allegations, insisting that no restrictions have been imposed on vehicles carrying essential goods and that supply deliveries are continuing.

However, a report in Dawn citing an anonymous official suggested that authorities had adopted several measures to contain the JAAC-led movement centred in Rawalakot. Among those measures was a strategy aimed at ending the sit-in without the use of force, including efforts to disrupt the flow of food and other supplies reaching protesters.

Whether those actions are directed solely at protesters or are affecting the wider civilian population remains unclear. What is evident is that shortages continue to deepen as the protest movement gains momentum.

Reports indicate that demonstrations have spread to numerous towns and villages across the territory. A mass sit-in at Rawalakot's Eidgah Ground has attracted large crowds, with more than 70,000 people reported to have joined the encampment over the past two weeks.

JAAC leaders have threatened to escalate the agitation further by organising a march of more than 100,000 people from Rawalakot to Muzaffarabad, setting the stage for a potentially larger confrontation between protesters and the Pakistani authorities.

WITH AGENCIES INPUTS

TRANSFORMING PUNJAB, TOUCHING LIVES

FROM HEALTHCARE AND EDUCATION TO AGRICULTURE, EMPLOYMENT AND PUBLIC SAFETY, PUNJAB'S DEVELOPMENT INITIATIVES ARE EXPANDING OPPORTUNITIES AND IMPROVING QUALITY OF LIFE ACROSS THE STATE

ASSURING FARMERS THEIR DUE

Punjab continues to play a central role in India's food security system through large-scale procurement operations. Over the last four years, government agencies have procured more than 1100 lakh metric tonnes of wheat and paddy, while over ₹2 lakh crore in Minimum Support Price (MSP) payments has been transferred directly into farmers' bank accounts.

The procurement process has consistently ensured that the overwhelming majority of crop arrivals in mandis are purchased at MSP, protecting farmers from market fluctuations and distress sales. Supported by an extensive network of procurement centres and digital payment systems, the mechanism has strengthened transparency while ensuring timely payments to lakhs of farmers across the state.

MUKH MANTRI SEHAT YOJANA Towards Universal Health Coverage

From universal healthcare and neighbourhood clinics to safer highways, Punjab is expanding access to essential services while improving quality of life across the state



Punjab has taken a significant step towards universal healthcare through the Mukh Mantri Sehat Yojana (MMSY), a programme designed to ensure that access to medical treatment is not determined by a family's financial circumstances. The scheme extends cashless treatment coverage of up to ₹10 lakh per family annually and is available to all residents of the state, irrespective of income category or social background. The initiative covers more than 2,000 medical procedures and treatments through an extensive network of empanelled public and private hospitals.

The scale of implementation has been substantial. More than 46 lakh health cards have already been generated, enabling lakhs of citizens to access treatment without the burden of arranging funds

during medical emergencies. The scheme operates through a network of 847 hospitals, including both government and private healthcare institutions, ensuring wider geographical reach and greater choice for patients.

Stories emerging from across Punjab underline the impact of the initiative. From elderly cancer patients receiving chemotherapy to infants undergoing critical treatment and families benefiting from cardiac procedures, dialysis, knee replacements and specialised surgeries, the programme is helping reduce out-of-pocket healthcare expenditure. By removing financial barriers and expanding access to quality medical care, the scheme seeks to strengthen the state's social security framework while improving health outcomes for millions of residents.

SADAK SURAKHYA FORCE

Making Highways Safer

Punjab's Sadak Surakhya Force (SSF) represents a specialised approach to road safety and emergency response. Dedicated exclusively to highway safety, the force has been deployed with trained personnel, advanced vehicles and modern equipment to ensure rapid assistance during accidents and emergencies. The model focuses on quick response, professional intervention and victim assistance during the critical "platinum hour" following road accidents.

Equipped with speed monitoring devices, breath analysers, e-challan systems, first-aid facilities and communication technology, the force patrols designated highway stretches across the state. According to official data, roads covered by



the SSF have witnessed a substantial reduction in fatalities since the force became operational, highlighting the role of timely intervention, specialised training and focused deployment in improving road safety outcomes.



₹1,791 crore
Sports Budget

68,228
Government Jobs

Punjab
Ranked Among India's
Top School Education
Performers

AAM AADMI CLINICS

Healthcare Closer To Home

Punjab's network of Aam Aadmi Clinics has emerged as a key pillar of primary healthcare delivery. Established to bring healthcare services closer to citizens, the state has rolled out 990 clinics across urban and rural areas, ensuring that essential medical consultation, medicines and diagnostic services are available within neighbourhood communities.

The clinics operate on a standardised model with trained medical personnel, digital patient records, free medicines and

diagnostic facilities. Patients visiting these centres receive access to 107 medicines and 47 diagnostic tests without charge. The use of digital systems has helped streamline registration, prescriptions and medicine dispensing while enabling real-time monitoring of services.

The response from citizens has been phenomenal. The clinics have collectively recorded more than 5.62 crore patient visits and have conducted over 3.43 crore diagnostic tests free of cost. On average, each clinic serves around 84 patients daily, contributing to an estimated 83,000 patient interactions every day across Punjab. Services have also expanded beyond routine consultations to include maternal healthcare, screening programmes and management of chronic diseases such as hypertension and diabetes.



REVIVING PUNJAB'S SPORTING LEGACY

Punjab has significantly expanded investment in sports infrastructure, increasing the sports budget to ₹1,791 crore for 2026-27 while accelerating the development of sports grounds across the state. The government has also expanded coaching strength and introduced support systems for athletes through direct preparation grants, enhanced nutrition support and specialised sports medicine services. Punjab is set to host the Asian Hockey Champions Trophy in October 2026, bringing a major international sporting event to the state for the first time.

RELIABLE AND AFFORDABLE ELECTRICITY

Punjab's power sector has witnessed major improvements in generation, transmission and service delivery. Nearly 90 per cent of households are benefiting from free electricity support, while farmers are receiving assured power supply during critical agricultural seasons. Infrastructure upgrades, enhanced transmission capacity and the acquisition of the Goindwal thermal plant have strengthened the state's energy security and helped improve operational efficiency.

STRENGTHENING LAW ENFORCEMENT

Operation Gangstran Te Vaar has intensified the state's action against organised crime through intelligence-led policing, inter-state coordination and technology-driven enforcement. Thousands of raids have been conducted, leading to arrests, preventive action and the recovery of arms, narcotics, cash and other illegal assets. The initiative focuses on disrupting criminal networks and improving public safety across Punjab.

EXPANDING OPPORTUNITIES FOR YOUTH

Punjab has provided more than 67,000 regular government jobs since 2022 through a recruitment process centred on merit and transparency. Alongside direct employment, investments are being made in skill development through new Industrial Training Institutes, upgraded technical education facilities and industry-linked internship programmes designed to improve employability and prepare young people for emerging sectors.

PUNJAB'S EDUCATION TRANSFORMATION

Punjab's school education reforms have earned national recognition, with the state emerging among India's best-performing education systems on several learning indicators. Government schools have recorded strong outcomes in foundational learning, while infrastructure upgrades, smart classrooms, Schools of Eminence and teacher training programmes have contributed to improved educational outcomes. The state has also introduced reforms aimed at making education more accessible, transparent and affordable for students and parents.



COMBATING THE DRUG MENACE

Punjab's anti-drug campaign 'Yudh Nasheyan Virudh' has combined enforcement, public awareness and rehabilitation efforts. The initiative has resulted in large-scale narcotics seizures, arrests of traffickers and action against financial networks linked to drug trafficking. Simultaneously, de-addiction and treatment programmes have been expanded to help individuals recover and reintegrate into society, reflecting a multi-pronged approach to tackling substance abuse.

A NEW ERA OF SUSTAINABLE IRRIGATION AND AGRICULTURAL GROWTH



Punjab's water landscape is undergoing a transformative change with a renewed focus on strengthening canal infrastructure, expanding irrigation access, and conserving groundwater. The Department of Water Resources, Punjab, has launched large-scale initiatives to modernise the state's ageing irrigation network and ensure dependable water availability for farmers.

With an investment of nearly ₹7,200 crore, extensive upgrades including canal lining, restoration of watercourses, pipeline networks, and infrastructure modernisation have been undertaken. Over 19,000 watercourses covering more than 7,400 km have been restored, improving last-mile connectivity and ensuring canal water reaches even the tail-end fields.

A significant achievement has been the revival of 102 abandoned canals, extending irrigation benefits to over 2.5 lakh acres of farmland. Several regions have

witnessed the return of canal water after decades, reducing dependence on groundwater and strengthening agricultural productivity. Major projects including the enhancement of the Sirhind Canal, relining of the Sirhind Feeder, and restoration of the Kandi Canal have further strengthened Punjab's irrigation backbone. The Kandi Canal revival has brought assured irrigation to thousands of acres across Hoshiarpur and surrounding areas, creating new opportunities for farmers.

Alongside expanding surface water availability, Punjab has prioritised groundwater conservation through recharge structures and sustainable water management practices. These efforts mark a decisive step towards a resilient water future, supporting farmers, protecting natural resources, and ensuring agricultural prosperity for generations ahead.

₹7,200
CRORE INVESTED
IN PUNJAB'S WATER
INFRASTRUCTURE
REVIVAL



BENGAL

Taratala warehouse collapse death toll climbs to 11, 6 held

CM announces Rs 10L ex-gratia for kin of deceased, Rs 1L for the injured

OUR CORRESPONDENT

KOLKATA: Nearly 24 hours after desperate cries for help first echoed from beneath the collapsed warehouse roof in Taratala, hope was giving way to grief on Thursday as the death toll rose to 11.

Police have so far arrested six individuals in the case, including Kalicharan Banerjee, Officer on Special Duty (OSD) to former Mayor Firhad Hakim. Banerjee was arrested on Thursday evening and is scheduled to be produced before a court on Friday.

Meanwhile, even as rescuers continued searching the mangled wreckage for anyone still trapped, Chief Minister Suwendu Adhikari announced Rs 10 lakh compensation for the family of each deceased worker and Rs 1 lakh for every injured person, vowing that those responsible would not be spared.

Addressing the Assembly, Adhikari alleged that the under-construction warehouse had been sanctioned despite serious structural deficiencies and claimed the approved building plan bore the signature of former Kolkata Mayor and Trinamool Congress MLA Firhad Hakim.

"This is the result of the sins you committed. By allowing such structures in exchange for money, you have turned the City of Joy and greater Kolkata into a city of death," the chief minister said.

He said the building plan, sanctioned on January 17, 2026, suffered from design flaws. Quoting a Kolkata Municipal Corporation (KMC) fact-finding report, Adhikari alleged that sub-assistant engineer Aminur Sheikh, assistant engineer Nirmalendu Sardar and executive engineer Ranjan Das had failed to discharge their duties. He also alleged that no building plan could be approved without the clearance of a person named 'Kali', whom he claimed was constructing the new Trinamool Bhavan.

Gulmarg Cable Car reopens after month-long shutdown

MPOST BUREAU

SRINAGAR: Jammu and Kashmir chief minister Omar Abdullah on Thursday reopened the Gulmarg Cable Car project to the public, a month after a technical snag forced the closure of the popular ride to the upper reaches of Gulmarg.

Abdullah, who visited the Cable Car Project in Gulmarg, Baramulla district, North Kashmir, told reporters that Gondola services resumed after the project underwent necessary repairs and maintenance.

"Gondola is working now. The interim report has arrived. Services resumed after the original manufacturer certified the maintenance and service works, based on the report and the inspection of the repair work," Abdullah said.

The chief minister said the government did not want to rush the reopening and ensured that all safety concerns were addressed and that due protocol was followed.

"The Cable Car corporation replaced the gearbox within four or five days (of the incident). We could have resumed the service if we had wanted to rush it, but we deliberately decided to wait for the interim report and inspection," he said. Officials said tourists can now book a gondola ride through the corporation's official portal.

On May 25, the army, police, NDRF and SDRF launched a rescue operation after the Gulmarg Cable Car services, popularly known as Gondola, developed a technical snag, leaving more than 300 tourists and local guides stranded mid-air, he said.



NDRF and Army officials carry the mortal remains of a victim during a rescue operation, on Thursday

The Narrative

Police have so far arrested six individuals in the case, including Kalicharan Banerjee, OSD to former Mayor Firhad Hakim

Suwendu Adhikari alleged that sub-assistant engineer Aminur Sheikh, assistant engineer Nirmalendu Sardar and executive engineer Ranjan Das had failed to discharge their duties

Those found guilty would face criminal prosecution and attachment of property to recover compensation.

Police have registered a suo motu case of culpable homicide not amounting to murder and other relevant charges. Besides Kalicharan Banerjee, five persons have been arrested — land lessee Sambhunath Behera, structural fabricator Kamal Samanta, supervisor Gulzar Hussain, labour supplier Dibakar Bhandari, Abdul Hamid, who allegedly brokered the sanctioned building plan. Additional Commissioner of Police (Crime) Kunal Agrawal said an SIT headed by ACP Joy-surja Mukherjee and the Detective Department were jointly probing the case. Two of the arrested have previous criminal records. Police are coordinating with the KMC on structural aspects of the collapsed warehouse, while the absence of any register documenting the workforce has made it difficult

to ascertain how many workers were present when the roof collapsed.

The death toll rose after two injured workers succumbed on Thursday. The deceased have been identified as Krishna Chowdhury (49), Rohit Chowdhury (20), Chandrama Chowdhury (60), Rahul Chowdhury (17), Pappu Kumar Rajak (40), Ghee Kumar (17), Asgar Hussain (54), Sahil Sardar (17), Hasan Imam (44), Ganesh Kalandi (45) and Navin Singh (44). Ganesh Kalandi died on Thursday morning, while Navin Singh was declared brought dead the same day. Nineteen injured workers remain admitted to SSKM Hospital, including one in a critical condition and four in a serious condition.

Rescue operations continued under the supervision of Health Secretary Narayan Swarup Nigam, Kolkata Police Commissioner Ajay Nanda and KMC Commissioner Smita Pandey. The Army deployed ground-penetrating radar, cameras and mobile phone tower data to locate anyone still trapped.

The Army's Eastern Command said seven specialised rescue teams, backed by medical personnel, ambulances and advanced engineering equipment, including cutting machinery and high-intensity illumination systems, remained deployed alongside the NDRF, SDRF and Kolkata Police. A fully equipped 10-bedded emergency medical facility with medical and surgical specialists was also operating at the site. The Army said 31 people had been rescued so far.

Praising the operation,

Adhikari said 215 Army personnel, particularly from the Bihar Regiment, and four NDRF teams had helped save lives. He alleged that the previous Trinamool Congress government had failed to develop modern disaster-response capabilities and had not involved the Army and NDRF during the 2024 Garden Reach building collapse.

The Chief Minister also announced a four-week suspension of all non-essential construction activity across the KMC area, Rajarhat-New Town, Maheshtala, Budge Budge, Pujali, Bishnupur Rural in Sonarpur and Baruripur. A committee headed by Additional Chief Secretary Rajesh Pandey, with representatives from the state administration, Kolkata Police, KMC, the Labour Department, Fire and Emergency Services, RITES, IRCON and IIT Kharagpur, will audit all sanctioned building plans.

Responding to the allegations, Firhad Hakim denied having any role in technically approving building plans, saying scrutiny was the responsibility of engineers and the Building Department, while the mayor's approval was only a statutory formality. He maintained that the warehouse was not being constructed illegally but acknowledged there appeared to have been inadequate supervision.

TMC MLA Kunal Ghosh said anyone found responsible, including Hakim, if evidence establishes his involvement, should be arrested, but cautioned against using the tragedy for political vendetta.

TMC MP Mahua Moitra questioned why officials who had approved the building plan had not been arrested and why no action had been taken against Hakim despite repeated references to his signature on the sanctioned plan. She alleged that if Hakim had remained in the Trinamool Congress, he and his family would already have been sent to jail.

Indigenous Netra AEW&C System gets Final Operational Clearance

MPOST BUREAU

BENGALURU: The indigenously developed Netra Airborne Early Warning and Control (AEW&C) System was accorded Final Operational Clearance (FOC) on Thursday, marking a significant milestone and paving the way for its full operational deployment by the Indian Air Force (IAF).

The FOC was formally declared by Air Marshal Awadhesh Kumar Bharti, Deputy Chief of the Air Staff, at a ceremony held at the Centre for Airborne Systems (CABS) in Bengaluru.

The indigenous Netra AEW&C system and the FOC certificate were also unveiled during the event.

Developed by the DRDO, the AEW&C system comprises advanced sensors mounted on an aircraft to detect and provide early warning of airborne and sea-surface targets, as well as hostile emissions. The system relays real-time information to onboard controllers and ground stations. Equipped with

radar, electronic warfare systems, secure communication and self-protection capabilities, the platform significantly enhances the IAF's surveillance and operational capabilities.

Describing the occasion as a proud moment, Air Marshal Bharti said the achievement represented not only the completion of an indigenous technology programme but also a successful partnership between the IAF and the scientific community in advancing the country's goal of self-reliance.

ROUND-THE-CLOCK SURVEILLANCE BY J&K POLICE

‘Project Hawk Eye’ launched for vigil along Amarnath Yatra trail

MPOST BUREAU

SRINAGAR: Police in Jammu and Kashmir's Anantnag district on Thursday launched 'Project Hawk Eye' -- a comprehensive surveillance and security initiative -- to ensure a secure and peaceful conduct of the annual Amarnath Yatra, set to commence July 3.

The initiative is aimed at maintaining round-the-clock vigilance from the sky and the ground along the entire yatra route, a police spokesman said.

Under this initiative, police deployed a multi-layered security and surveillance grid by integrating advanced technology with strategic manpower deployment, he said.

The official said to maintain aerial surveillance, five drones detts will be deployed at key locations, providing real-time monitoring and enhanced situational awareness. The aerial surveillance network enables quick assessment of any emerging situation and facilitates prompt response by ground units.



Security officials keep vigil through CCTV monitoring as part of the 'Project Hawk Eye', to strengthen surveillance and security arrangements for the upcoming Shri Amarnath Ji Yatra 2026, in Anantnag district

Drone detts refer to specialised teams of UAV (unmanned aerial vehicle) operators and anti-drone units, deployed for security and surveillance.

On the ground, 28 strategically located 'Machan Morchas' (elevated observation posts) have been established at sensitive locations to strengthen vigilance and area domination, the spokesman said.

He said 22 specially trained sniper teams have also been stationed at designated points to further reinforce the security grid and ensure effective response preparedness.

To augment the surveillance framework, 416 high-resolution CCTV cameras and facial recognition system (FRS) infrastructure have been installed at critical locations along the yatra route, he said. These systems provide con-

OVER 80 LOCATIONS SEARCHED UNDER OPERATION CHAKRA-VI

Digital arrest scams: CBI conducts raids across 16 states, arrests two key accused

NARESH BISWANI

NEW DELHI: In a major offensive against cybercrime networks facilitating digital arrest scams, the Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) launched a massive nationwide operation under Operation Chakra-VI, conducting coordinated searches at over 80 locations across 16 states and arresting two individuals allegedly linked to the fraudulent racket.

Across multiple states - Punjab, Gujarat, Delhi, Maharashtra, Haryana, Tamil Nadu, Telangana, Andhra Pradesh, Uttar Pradesh, Madhya Pradesh, Rajasthan, Assam, West Bengal, Manipur, Karnataka, and Odisha - searches took place. Conducted by 60 dedicated CBI units formed specifically for this purpose, the effort forms one phase of a broader inquiry.

This network under scrutiny



REPRESENTATIVE PIC

tiny appears linked to over 200 incidents classified as digital arrest scams. While complexity marks its structure, evidence collection remains methodical. Investigations continue through such channels. At least temporarily, movement of those sums has been traced back through layered transfers.

B. Naresh was taken into custody from Chennai by the CBI, while Sanjib Saha was detained from Kolkata. These individuals face allegations tied to fabricated firms and financial pathways meant to redirect

B. Naresh was taken into custody from Chennai by the CBI, while Sanjib Saha was detained from Kolkata

funds gained via online deception. Accounts linked to them served as conduits - handling transactions under suspicion. Early findings point to close to Rs 20 crore flowing through such channels. At least temporarily, movement of those sums has been traced back through layered transfers.

Following the detection of a counterfeit site using a domain closely resembling the Supreme Court of India's, authorities moved swiftly. Officials suspect digital attackers impersonated judicial personnel

through this platform, asserting untruthful charges were filed against targeted individuals. Because of these developments, a formal police report emerged after notification from the court's administrative office. Charges proceed under criminal procedures triggered by official grievance. The appearance of such mimicry online prompted an immediate investigative response. Legal steps now follow standard protocol for cyber deception cases.

From digital traces left behind, key parts of a crime network spanning India and foreign locations came into view through careful examination. Though appearing official, court directives and papers tied to police or courts turned out to be fabricated upon inspection. These counterfeit materials had been placed online, serving as false proof meant to support fraudulent operations.

Hry notifies Model Online Transfer Policy

CHANDIGARH: The Haryana government on Thursday notified the Model Online Transfer Policy 2026, introducing a transparent and merit-based system for the transfer and posting of regular government employees across state departments. The notification was issued by Chief Secretary Anurag Rastogi.

The policy applies to regular employees in cadres with a sanctioned strength of 50 or more posts across government departments. However, it excludes All India Services and Haryana Civil Services (Executive Branch) and Allied Services. The Human Resources Department has been empowered to extend the policy to smaller cadres, if required. MPOST

‘Clash at J&K police station’: Army officer and jawans booked

JAMMU: Tensions flared between personnel of the Indian Army and the Jammu and Kashmir Police in Atholi area of Kishtwar district after an alleged altercation led to the registration of an FIR against several Army personnel, including a Commanding Officer.

The incident reportedly occurred following a dispute during a routine traffic check. However, locals claimed that the confrontation began when the convoy of Kishtwar Deputy Commissioner Pankaj Sharma encountered a private vehicle driven by an Army soldier on a narrow road during a Block Diwas programme. An argument reportedly broke out over giving way to the convoy, after which police impounded the

vehicle and took it to Atholi police station.

Though the vehicle was later released following intervention by Army officers, tensions allegedly escalated. Police alleged that nearly 90 minutes later, around 30 to 40 personnel from the 17 Rashtriya Rifles camp at Kijayee entered the Atholi police station and assaulted police personnel.

The FIR names Commanding Officer Colonel N. Arun Gandhi, Major Vikas Sharma, Naib Subedar Shanker Gurkhe and several soldiers, besides 30 to 40 unidentified Army personnel. They have been booked under multiple provisions of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita, the Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita and the Prevention of Damage to Public Property Act.

Police officials said Station House Officer Amrit Katoch, SDPO Vijay Bhagat, an SPO, ARTO Tasleem Javed Wani and security personnel sustained injuries during the incident. Government property and official vehicles were also allegedly damaged.

The Army said the matter was being examined through appropriate institutional mechanisms and assured full cooperation with the investigation. A defence spokesperson stated that appropriate action would be taken based on the findings of the joint inquiry.

The case is being investigated by Sub-Inspector Adarsh Kant. Officials said the injured personnel are in stable condition. MPOST

‘Mask was used’: Mann denies video link

MPOST BUREAU

CHANDIGARH: Punjab Chief Minister Bhagwant Mann on Thursday strongly denied allegations linking him to a controversial video that has triggered a political and religious controversy in the state, asserting that the person seen in the clip was wearing a mask resembling his face.

Addressing a press conference in Mohali, Mann presented what he described as fresh evidence to support his claim that the individual in the purported objectionable video was not him. He alleged that a person based in Canada had procured a face mask resembling him and used it to create the video.

"The biggest truth about this video is being revealed today. After this, there should be no doubt left. The Sikh sangat will



Punjab CM Bhagwant Mann addresses a press conference

decide," Mann said.

The controversy dates back to January when the Chief Minister was summoned by the Akal Takht over alleged remarks concerning "Guru ki Golak" and for purported involvement in objectionable activities shown in a video containing photographs of Sikh Gurus and slain militant Jarnail Singh Bhindranwale. When he appeared before the Akal Takht

in January, Mann had maintained that the clip was either fake or generated using artificial intelligence and had suggested a forensic examination by any laboratory in the country. Reiterating his stand, Mann said the person in the video did not match his physical appearance. He pointed to the absence of a surgical scar on the throat, which he said he bears, and claimed that the individual in the clip wore sunglasses to conceal his identity.

The Chief Minister identified a Canada-based individual, Jagman Samra, alleging that he had obtained the mask and later recorded videos displaying it. Mann claimed that the controversial clip was filmed in a hotel room in Abbotsford, Canada, adding that he had not visited the country since 2016, while the alleged video surfaced only

after 2017-18.

He further alleged that the same person had also arranged a mask resembling AAP leader Arvind Kejriwal. "Who financed this operation and who produced and directed this video will be revealed in the coming days," Mann said.

Mann said he would submit the new material to the Akal Takht for examination and reiterated his willingness to appear before the Sikh clergy if summoned again.

Meanwhile, the controversy has intensified after the Akal Takht issued an edict against the chief minister earlier this month, citing forensic reports that reportedly found the video to be authentic. Opposition parties, including the Congress, Shiromani Akali Dal and BJP, have continued to target Mann over the issue.

Nation Briefs

MAHA: NEET ASPIRANT ENDS LIFE AFTER RECORDING VIDEO FOR MOTHER

HINGOLI: An 18-year-old student from Maharashtra's Hingoli, who recently took the NEET-UG re-test, allegedly died by suicide after recording a video for his mother on his mobile phone, officials said on Thursday. A probe is underway to determine whether the extreme step taken by Sushil Dhage had anything to do with the entrance examination amid claims by his family that he had found the retest difficult, they said. Dhage (18), who lived in the Ashtavinayak Nagar area of the city, jumped into a well around 10.30 am on Wednesday, an official told reporters. Before he died by suicide, Sushil recorded a 33-second video apologising to his mother for committing suicide.

AMBUBACHI MELA: NFR ORGANISES FOOD DISTRIBUTION PROGRAMME

MALIGAON: In a continued effort to support the large number of devotees visiting Kamakhya Temple during the annual Ambubachi Mela, the Northeast Frontier Railway Women's Welfare Organization (NFRWWO), led by its president Shalini Shrivastava, organised a food distribution programme at Kamakhya Railway Station.



POLITICAL, LEGAL HEAT MOUNTS OVER 'EMBEZZLEMENT'

Ram temple donation row: Oppn questions timing of FIR

MPOST BUREAU

LUCKNOW: Opposition parties in Uttar Pradesh stepped up their attack on the BJP government on Thursday after an FIR was lodged in connection with the alleged embezzlement of donations at the Ram temple in Ayodhya, with Samajwadi Party president Akhilesh Yadav and Uttar Pradesh Congress chief Ajay Rai questioning the timing and scope of the police action. Police in Ayodhya registered the FIR on Thursday following a complaint from a member of the Shri Ram Janmabhoomi Teerth Kshetra Trust, hours after the Vishva Hindu Parishad (VHP) also backed demands for a criminal case in the matter. In a post on X, Yadav alleged that the FIR was preceded by efforts to shield influential persons. "In BJP rule, this is how injustice will be displayed: the tip of the tree will be hanged while the branches will be forgiven," he said.



Congress workers protest outside the district headquarters over the alleged theft of donation deeds linked to the Shri Ram Temple in Ayodhya, in Varanasi, Wednesday

"The public is saying that first, under the pretext of the SIT, all evidence would have been cleaned up and it would have been decided which big fish had to be saved and who had to be trapped. Only after that has the FIR been registered," he added. "It appears the SIT report was prepared in advance and the investigation was conducted accordingly, meaning the conclusion had already been reached beforehand," the

former Uttar Pradesh chief minister added. Rai said the Congress had raised the issue across Uttar Pradesh and demanded the registration of an FIR in connection with the alleged donation embezzlement. "Our party raised its voice in every district of the state over the theft and embezzlement of offerings at the Ayodhya Ram temple and demanded that an FIR be registered. We had also submit-

SC asks petitioner to mention plea on June 29

NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court on Thursday asked a petitioner to mention before it on June 29 his plea seeking registration of an FIR, and a fair and time-bound probe into the alleged embezzlement of donations received at the Ram temple in Ayodhya. The matter was mentioned for urgent listing before a bench of Justices B V Nagarathna and Joymalya Bagchi. The petition, filed by practising advocates Ajay Kumar Rai and Dinesh Kumar Yadav, said a CBI-led multi-disciplinary special investigation team (SIT) should investigate the alleged

financial irregularities and other purported illegalities concerning the affairs and administration of the Shri Ram Janmabhoomi Teerth Kshetra Trust. On Thursday, one of the petitioners mentioned the matter and urged the bench that the plea be listed for hearing on June 29. "This is a PIL (public interest litigation) and it relates to the Shri Ram Janmabhoomi Teerth Kshetra Trust. It has been numbered but no date is shown," the petitioner said. The bench observed if there was no deficiency in the plea, the registry would process it.

people under whose supervision the entire Ram temple and trust function -- Nripendra Misra, Champat Rai, Gopal Rao and Anil Mishra -- are not there, despite allegations of corruption against them," he said. Rai further alleged that workers associated with the temple had claimed that commissions of up to 40 per cent were sought from them. "All this proves that the FIR has been lodged only

accused the Bharatiya Janata Party-led government of protecting certain individuals linked to the case. "When allegations are being made against the trust chairman, who has also served as the secretary to the prime minister, why is no case being registered against him? It is because he enjoys the prime minister's protection. The same is true of Champat Rai and Anil Mishra. That is why all these people are being protected," Rai alleged. "This entire episode shows that even in the offerings made to Lord Ram, there is discrimination in the action being taken and theft is being facilitated," he added. Meanwhile, AAP national convener Arvind Kejriwal questioned the role of the Ayodhya Ram temple's trust leadership, asking how its secretary Champat Rai could find the 'courage' to refuse to provide details to Prime Minister Narendra Modi. Addressing reporters at Lucknow airport before leaving for Ayodhya, Kejriwal alleged that reports of the alleged disappearance of cash, jewellery and other offerings made by devotees had deeply hurt the sentiments of millions of people. "(Ram Janmabhoomi Teerth Kshetra Trust Secretary) Champat Rai refused to give an account even to the prime minister. How did he gather such courage? What secrets does he know that even the prime minister appears helpless before him?" he asked. Kejriwal further alleged that the Special Investigation Team (SIT) probing the allegations of embezzlement of donations received at the Ram temple was meant to protect influential people. Earlier in the day, AAP Rajya Sabha MP Sanjay Singh appeared before the SIT probing the alleged Ram Temple donation scam and related cases and submitted documents which he claimed contained evidence of corruption.

PROMINENCE TO OBCS, YOUTH & WOMEN AHEAD OF 2027 POLLS

BJP's UP team signals social engineering push

BISWAJEET BANERJEE

LUCKNOW: The Bharatiya Janata Party's newly constituted Uttar Pradesh executive committee reflects a carefully calibrated social and caste balancing exercise as the party prepares for the 2027 Assembly elections. The new team appears aimed at consolidating support among non-Yadav OBCs, Dalits, women and youth, while retaining the BJP's traditional upper-caste base. The 49-member state executive, announced by state BJP president Pankaj Chaudhary, comprises 19 vice presidents, eight general secretaries, five joint general secretaries and 19 secretaries. Regional presidents have also been appointed for the party's six organisa-



tional zones — Western Uttar Pradesh, Braj, Kanpur-Bundelkhand, Awadh, Kashi and Gorakhpur. The appointments indicate a conscious effort to broaden social representation. Among the general secretaries, Geeta Shakyas, Shankar Lodhi, Dilip Patel and Rajesh Chaudhary represent influential backward communities, including the Shakyas, Lodhi, Kurmi and Jat groups. At the same time,

the BJP has retained its traditional upper-caste leadership presence through leaders such as Rampratap Singh Chauhan, Abhijai Mishra and Sanjay Rai. The vice-presidents' list also reflects social balancing. Former minister Suresh Rana and Neeraj Singh represent the Thakur community, while Archana Mishra is among the prominent Brahmin faces. Former Barabanki MP Priyanka Rawat has also been appointed vice president. The party has expanded the representation of non-Yadav OBC leaders, including Pooja Pal and Dhruv Vijay Shakyas, indicating its continued focus on communities that have contributed significantly to its electoral success over the past decade.

Western Uttar Pradesh, a politically crucial region, has received particular attention. Former minister Suresh Rana has been made vice president, while prominent Gujar leader Nawab Singh Nagar has been appointed regional president of western Uttar Pradesh. Women and younger leaders have also found greater representation. Four women have been appointed vice presidents, while Geeta Shakyas has been made a general secretary. Rohit Mishra will head the Bharatiya Janata Yuva Morcha in the state and Saroj Kushwaha will lead the Mahila Morcha. The new executive is expected to play a crucial role in shaping the BJP's organisational and electoral strategy in Uttar Pradesh.

Shah calls on Prez amid buzz of reshuffle of council of ministers

NEW DELHI: Union Home minister Amit Shah on Thursday called on President Droupadi Murmu at the Rashtrapati Bhavan here amid the buzz over a reshuffle of the Union council of ministers.



President Droupadi Murmu with Union Home Minister Amit Shah during a meeting, at Rashtrapati Bhavan

The President's office shared a picture of the meeting in a post on X. "Union Minister for Home Affairs and Cooperation Shri Amit Shah called on President Droupadi Murmu at Rashtrapati Bhavan," the post said. On Tuesday, Prime Minister Narendra Modi had called on President Murmu. The meetings assume significance given the speculation that a reshuffle of the union council of ministers is imminent. Veteran BJP leader from Kerala George Kurian recently

resigned from the council of ministers after his Rajya Sabha term expired. The 65-year-old was Union minister of state for minority affairs and also for fisheries, animal husbandry and dairying. Besides, Minister of State

for Railways Ravneet Singh, whose Rajya Sabha term also ended on June 21, has not been renominated to the Upper House either. Singh also holds charge as the minister of state for food processing industries. A few Union ministers have been given key organisational responsibilities in their home states. Their appointment fuelled the buzz of a possible reshuffle. BJP national president Nitin Nabin on May 28 appointed Union Minister of State for Road Transport and Highways and Corporate Affairs Harsh Malhotra as Delhi BJP chief. In December last year, Union Minister of State for Finance Pankaj Chaudhary was the new president of the BJP's Uttar Pradesh unit. MPOST

Emergency darkest chapter of Indian democracy: Haryana CM

CHANDIGARH: Haryana Chief Minister Nayab Singh Saini on Thursday said the sacrifices made by 'Loktantra Senanis' -- those who fought against the Emergency -- are part of an invaluable national heritage and will continue to inspire future generations to protect democracy and uphold constitutional values. Addressing a function organised in Panchkula to mark the 51 years of Emergency, Saini said June 25, 1975, remains a dark chapter in India's democratic history when democratic rights were curtailed, and an Emergency was imposed across the country. He honoured several Loktantra Senanis with ceremonial stoles and certificates of appreciation. MPOST

Farmers' bodies join hands against proposed India-US trade agreement

CHANDIGARH: Farmers' organisations from several states criticised the Centre on Thursday regarding the proposed India-US trade deal, warning that its implementation could harm the interests of the farming community. Representatives from various farmers' groups, including the Samyukta Kisan Morcha (Non-Political), Azad Kisan Morcha Punjab, Kisan Mazdoor Sangharsh Morcha, and Rashtriya Kisan Mahasangh, gathered for a meeting in Chandigarh. The representatives came from states such as Haryana, Punjab, Rajasthan, Maharashtra, Kerala, Odisha, Uttar

Pradesh, Uttarakhand, and Madhya Pradesh. During the meeting, farmer leaders discussed the potential negative impacts of the proposed India-US trade deal on farmers, labourers, and small traders. They asserted that they would not accept any compromise on issues related to agriculture, animal husbandry, employment, and food security. They warned that its implementation could harm the interests of the farming community

The farmers warned that if the government ignores their concerns, the united front would be forced to initiate a nationwide movement. They argued that this trade deal could pose a significant threat to the interests of farmers, livestock rearers, labourers, and the general public. In response, all organisations agreed to set aside their differences and unite on a common platform to confront this issue. To determine their future strategy, the representatives resolved to hold a meeting on July 1 in Chandigarh, with five key representatives from each participating forum and organisation. MPOST

Govt invites entries for PM Rashtriya Bal Puraskar

NEW DELHI: The government has invited nominations for the Pradhan Mantri Rashtriya Bal Puraskar 2026, a national honour for children aged 5 to 18, with July 31 set as the last date for submission. In a statement, the Ministry of Women and Child Development said the award recognises exceptional achievements by children in bravery, social service, environment, sports, art & culture, and Science & Technology, and celebrates their "exceptional resilience, courage, creativity, and indomitable spirit". The ministry said the award will be conferred by the President at a special ceremony in New Delhi on Veer Bal Diwas on December 26. "The award serves to encourage and inspire young talent by acknowledging their contributions at the national level and motivating others to strive for excellence," it said. MPOST

QR codes now must on vaccines, antimicrobials and cancer drugs

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: The Centre has widened the scope of its QR code-based track-and-trace system for medicines, bringing all antimicrobials, vaccines, anti-cancer drugs, and narcotic and psychotropic medicines under a stricter product verification framework aimed at tackling counterfeit and substandard medicines. The Union Health Ministry has notified amendments to the Drugs Rules, 1945, placing these categories under Schedule H2. The revised rules make it mandatory for manufacturers to print or affix a barcode or Quick Response (QR) code on the primary packaging label of drug formulations. In cases where there is not enough space, the code can be placed on the secondary packaging. According to the ministry, the QR code will enable authentication and verification of medicines through software applications across the supply chain. The code will carry important details, including a unique product identification number,

generic and brand names, manufacturer's name and address, batch number, manufacturing and expiry dates, manufacturing licence number, and information on excipients wherever applicable. The ministry said that until now the requirement applied only to the country's top 300 pharmaceutical brands. The latest amendment significantly expands its reach to cover all vaccines, antimicrobials, anti-cancer medicines, and narcotic and psychotropic drugs regulated under the Narcotic Drugs and Psychotropic Substances (NDPS) Act, 1985. Officials said the strengthened traceability mechanism is expected to improve safeguards against counterfeit and substandard medicines by allowing verification of products at different stages of the supply chain. The ministry added that the measure would help curb the circulation of spurious medicines and support efforts to combat antimicrobial resistance (AMR) through better identification and monitoring of fake or poor-quality antimicrobial products.

PROCEDURAL LAPSES DECRIMINALISED Health ministry notifies 'Jan Vishwas' reforms in Clinical Establishments Act

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: The Union Health Ministry has notified amendments to the Clinical Establishments (Registration and Regulation) Act, 2010, replacing criminal penalties for certain procedural violations with an administrative adjudication mechanism as part of the Jan Vishwas reforms. The amendments, notified on June 22, operationalise provisions of the Jan Vishwas (Amendment of Provisions) Act, 2026, which seeks to decriminalise minor procedural non-compliances across multiple central laws and promote trust-based governance. The Jan Vishwas law, published in April this year, and aimed at reducing compliance burden and improving ease of doing business, amends provisions across 79 Central Acts administered by 23 ministries and departments. In the health sector, 35 provisions spread across five laws under the Ministry of Health and Family Welfare have been modified, a statement by the ministry said. Under the amended frame-

KEY POINTS

- » The Jan Vishwas law, published in April this year, aimed at reducing compliance burden and improving ease of doing business
- » The amendments, notified on June 22, seeks to decriminalise minor procedural non-compliances across multiple central laws and



- promote trust-based governance
- » Under the amended framework, the term 'fine' has been replaced with 'penalty' in Sections 40, 43 and 46 of the Act

work, the term "fine" has been replaced with "penalty" in Sections 40, 43 and 46 of the Act, shifting the enforcement framework from criminal prosecution to administrative adjudication. Section 44 has been amended to introduce graded and proportionate penalties for contraventions committed by companies, ensuring that enforcement action is commensurate with the nature and severity of the violation, the statement said. Further, the adjudicating

authority mechanism under Section 41 has been strengthened and its scope expanded to cover proceedings under sections 40, 43 and 44, facilitating transparent, efficient and accountable enforcement, it stated. The amendments also provide for a structured adjudication process, including an opportunity for a hearing before the imposition of penalties, mechanisms for recovery of penalties, and an appeal framework for aggrieved parties.

Development Commissioner (Handlooms) वस्त्र मंत्रालय MINISTRY OF TEXTILES Govt. of India National Design Centre India Handloom "सूत संगम - A Confluence of Threads" #Myproductmypride #Myhandloommypride Special Handloom Expo 24th June - 01st July 2026 Handloom Haat, Janpath, New Delhi Ground and First Floor ENTRY FREE

MAX Healthcare 25 YEARS OF SERVICE AND EXCELLENCE PUBLIC NOTICE FOR THE FAMILIES WHOSE ANNUAL INCOME IS LESS THAN ₹5,00,000/- The general public is hereby informed that as per Order No.F13 (906) /DGHS/HQ/EWS /2025/13-19 issued by the Directorate General of Health Services (DGHS), dated 02.01.2026, and in compliance with the orders of the Hon'ble High Court, Max Super Speciality Hospital, Patparganj (A Unit of Balaji Medical and Diagnostic Research Centre) is providing free OPD and IPD treatment to patients under the EWS (Economically Weaker Section) category whose income is less than Rs. 5,00,000/- per annum. For more information, please contact the Nodal Officer Max Super Speciality Hospital, Patparganj (A Unit of Balaji Medical and Diagnostic Research Centre) 108 A, Indraprastha Extension, Patparganj, New Delhi-110092 Mr Sunil Kumar (Nodal Officer) 8800913222

SHATTERED HOMES, CROWDED HOSPS: TREMORS LEAVE TRAIL OF DESTRUCTION

‘Like a horror movie’: Venezuela quake survivors stumble through ruin

CARACAS: What began as a public holiday afternoon on Wednesday ended in scenes of devastation and panic as two powerful earthquakes struck Venezuela within seconds of each other, reducing apartment blocks to mountains of concrete and trapping unknown numbers beneath the rubble.

As darkness fell over Caracas, rescue workers clambered across pancaked buildings illuminated by floodlights, while desperate relatives called out the names of loved ones feared trapped inside. Survivors emerged dazed and dust-covered from shattered homes, recounting moments of terror as the ground lurched beneath them.



A woman walks past a building damaged in La Guaira

“When we went downstairs, the scene was like a horror movie,” said Maria Alejandra, a resident living near one of the collapsed buildings. “We had to climb over the rubble. I only saw one family make it out.”

The twin tremors — measuring 7.2 and 7.5 in magnitude — struck less than a minute apart west of the capital, sending shockwaves across the country and triggering wide-

spread panic. Residents rushed into streets as walls cracked, ceilings crumbled and clouds of dust engulfed neighbourhoods.

Officials confirmed at least over 160 deaths and hundreds of injuries, though the toll was expected to rise sharply as rescuers reached the hardest-hit areas. Thousands were reported missing or unaccounted for in the hours after the disaster, while hospitals prepared for an

influx of casualties and emergency crews searched relentlessly through the night for signs of life.

Residents fill streets

Wilmer Azuaje, a former Venezuelan lawmaker, captured the moment the quake hit Maiquetia Airport, sending masonry and clouds of dust falling.

“Everyone, the situation we’re experiencing here is seri-

Summary

» Video footage showed emergency workers scrambling over the pancaked debris of a collapsed building in the capital as night fell, while distraught relatives sought help for loved ones believed to be trapped

» “When we went downstairs, the scene was like a horror movie,” said Maria Alejandra, a resident

ous. A high-magnitude earthquake. Look at how everything ended up,” he said while videoing the scene.

A tsunami warning was issued but swiftly canceled after the danger passed.

Residents across Caracas, which was also hit by a deadly magnitude 6.3 earthquake in 1967, rushed to evacuate as buildings shook.

“As soon as it started, we began hearing people scream-

ing,” said Astrid Ramirez, a 41-year-old publicist in western Caracas. “Everyone was running down the stairs.”

Maria Romero, an 80-year-old pensioner in southern Caracas, said police helped her get out of her home. “This earthquake was horrible, even worse than the one in 1967,” she said.

Another resident, a 41-year-old office worker who declined to be named, said she received an earthquake alert on her phone just before the shaking intensified.

“As I picked it up and started listening to what it was saying, I first felt light shaking. Then, in less than two seconds, everything started moving.”

Leaders from countries including El Salvador, the Dominican Republic, Brazil and Spain offered support and sympathy, while the U.S. State Department said it was in touch with Venezuelan authorities and mobilizing assistance.

The U.S. embassy in Caracas said it was closely monitoring the aftermath of the quake and urged citizens in the country to seek secure shelter. **MP0ST**

Oil tankers stick to Hormuz despite threats, use new route

Vessels adjusting their paths through the chokepoint



Tankers and cargo vessels are seen in the Gulf of Oman

Traffic through the strait has increased but is still well below pre-war levels

DUBAI: Several tankers made their way out of the Strait of Hormuz on Thursday using a new route promoted by a U.N. maritime agency. Iran has threatened vessels using the path, which runs along the coast of Oman.

The opening of an alternative passage through the vital waterway would relieve pressure on the world economy and remove Iran’s main source of leverage in ongoing talks about the interim deal signed last week with the United States.

Traffic through the strait has increased but is still well below prewar levels. Oil on Thursday briefly dipped below its last prewar price of just under \$73 per barrel, a sign that the market believes the situation is improving.

The two sides are still debating terms of the deal — from getting ships through the narrow mouth of the Persian Gulf to the future of Iran’s stockpile of highly enriched uranium.

Under the memorandum of understanding, the U.S. and Iran agreed to a 60-day period to iron out the details. As talks are held behind closed doors, U.S. President Donald Trump

a ceasefire took effect over the weekend killed two people on Wednesday, according to Lebanon’s state-news agency.

The oil tankers, led by the Stoic Warrior vessel, sailed along the coast of the United Arab Emirates and then Oman early Thursday, passing by Oman’s Musandam Peninsula fairly close to the shore. The route was laid out by Oman and the International Maritime Organization, a U.N. agency. North of the route is the Traffic Separation Scheme corridor, in the center of the strait, where ships had moved through freely before the war, transporting about a fifth of all the world’s oil and natural gas. **AGENCIES**

‘Burnham would provide stability as PM’

LONDON: British finance minister Rachel Reeves said on Thursday she was backing Andy Burnham to be the next prime minister, adding that he would stick to her fiscal rules and provide stability while brushing off reports she could be moved to a more junior post.

Reeves told the BBC she was backing Burnham to be prime minister after he emerged as the only declared candidate to replace Keir Starmer, who announced his resignation on Monday.

Later she went further, saying that Burnham “will be the next prime minister” and had been clear that he was committed to her fiscal rules, which include balancing day-to-day spending with tax revenues and reducing debt as a share of output. “That is a good thing because it means that businesses here can be confident that that stability, that rigour to policymaking, that tight grip on the public finances... will be continued,” she said at a British Chambers of Commerce

Starmer said he would oversee an orderly transition to a new PM

conference.

Starmer said he would oversee an orderly transition to a new prime minister from his Labour Party, after bowing to pressure over weak poll ratings and poor local election results.

Burnham, who is the only candidate to have put his name forward to replace Starmer, is widely expected to be installed without a challenge, meaning he could become prime minister by mid-July. If appointed, he would be Britain’s seventh leader in a decade. Asked if she wanted to stay as finance minister, Reeves said she wouldn’t pre-empt cabinet decisions, which would be a matter for Burnham. Media reports have suggested she will be moved to a more junior role. **AGENCIES**

EU unlocks 3 billion-euro lifeline for Ukraine

WARSAW: The European Union has disbursed the first 3 billion-euro (USD 3.4 billion) tranche of a 90 billion-euro (USD 101 billion) loan to Ukraine, the country’s prime minister announced Thursday at the opening of a conference on Ukraine’s post-war recovery in Poland.

The conference, attended by key European leaders including German Chancellor Friedrich Merz and European Commission President Ursula von der Leyen, is both a fund-raising forum and a message to Russia that Ukraine’s Western supporters are in it for the long haul. “We are forced to innovate to survive, and this has become our superpower,” Ukrainian Prime Minister Yulia Svyrydenko said, adding that Ukraine was grateful for



European nations vowed commitment and investments for Ukraine

the support promised to her war-battered nation.

Von der Leyen reassured the EU’s financial commitment to Ukraine, just days after the country officially started EU membership negotiations on June 15.

Since the beginning of Russia’s full-scale invasion in February 2022, EU countries have

provided 200 billion euros (USD 225 billion) in economic, financial and military support to Ukraine, and approved 90 billion euros (USD 101 billion) more over the next two years in the form of an EU support loan, she said. The EU will also start paying another 6 billion euros (USD 6.7 billion), a second tranche from the loan ded-

EU also will start paying another 6 billion euros, a second tranche from loan

icated to drone production, “in the coming days,” she added.

In a separate initiative, European leaders meeting in Gdansk said they’re kicking off a European equity fund dedicated to investments in strategic sectors of the Ukrainian economy. “With an initial public package of up to 220 million euros, we are creating the confidence and the risk-sharing mechanism that private investors need to engage now,” Merz said. **AGENCIES**

Zelenskyy says Russia shifting air defences to Moscow after strikes

KYIV: Russia is moving a significant part of its air defences to protect a handful of prime targets, including Moscow, as Ukraine’s long-range drones continue to hammer sites deep inside the country, Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy says.

In new overnight strikes, meanwhile, Zelenskyy said Thursday that Kyiv’s forces hit two more Russian oil refineries in Ufa, 1,500 kilometres from the front line, and an oil depot in the Krasnodar

region, 300 kilometres from Ukraine.

Ukraine has in recent months stepped up its aerial campaign against Russian military installations and energy facilities. Its success has caused fuel shortages and disrupted army supply lines, stalling Moscow’s full-scale invasion of its neighbour after more than four years of fighting and rattling Russian officials.

Zelenskyy said in his daily address late Wednesday that Russia is moving more air

defences to the capital as well as to Valdai, a town some 500 kilometres northwest of Moscow where Russian President Vladimir Putin has a residence, and to protect the Kerch Bridge, a vital supply route connecting the Crimean Peninsula with the Russian mainland.

“In the Moscow region alone, they have amassed hundreds of launchers” for air defence missiles, Zelenskyy said. “Nearly 90 launchers have been redeployed to Valdai from other regions of Russia.” **AGENCIES**

Senate Republicans reject war powers resolution on Iran



Donald Trump berated them at Capitol meeting

WASHINGTON: Senate Republicans who were berated by President Donald Trump over opposition to his war in Iran held a late-night vote Wednesday to try to appease him, rejecting a war powers resolution a day after a similar measure passed.

Trump harangued GOP senators face to face earlier in the day for allowing a vote to block his war in Iran on Tuesday, further escalating a feud that has diverted GOP efforts to focus on election-year affordability issues and brought much of the chamber’s business to a halt. He exchanged particularly harsh words with Louisiana Sen. Bill Cassidy, one of four Republicans who had voted with Democrats on the measure.

Hours later, though, Cassidy was invited to receive a personal briefing on the war at the White House from

Vice President JD Vance and envoy Steve Witkoff. Cassidy then returned to the Capitol to vote against a separate but nearly identical war powers resolution. “I want to thank Vice President Vance and Special Envoy Witkoff for the thorough briefing this afternoon on Iran. I appreciate the quick invitation to the White House to address many of my concerns,” said Cassidy, who lost reelection last month after Trump endorsed his opponent, in a post on X.

Kentucky Sen. Rand Paul, a Republican who has repeatedly voted with Democrats to halt the war, voted present this time “to give the President more space and leverage to negotiate a lasting peace,” he said on X. The measure failed 47-50-1 just before midnight on Wednesday, and the Senate then left town for a 2-week recess. **AGENCIES**

OFFICE OF THE EXECUTIVE ENGINEER PWD(R&B) DIVISION VIJAYPUR

ABBREVIATED NOTICE INVITING TENDER

e-NIT No. 28 of 2026-27 Dated. 24-06-2026

For and on behalf of the Lieutenant Governor, Union Territory of Jammu and Kashmir e-tenders are invited on percentage basis from approved and eligible Contractors registered with Union Territory of J&K, CPWD, Railways, MES and other State/Central Governments for each of the following works

S.No.	Name of Work	Estimated cost of Work (in Lacs)	Cost of Tender Doc. (in Rs.)	Earnest Money (in Rs.)	Time allowed for completion	Class of Contractor
1	2	3	4	5	6	7
1	Const. / Repair / Widening of road in the Vill. Ranjri, Vijaypur by way of constructing drain, Riwall, Edge wall, 150mm thick Gr-II, 75mm thick WMM, 50mm thick BM & 30mm thick SDBC.	141.83	3000	2% of Adv. Cost	12 Months	"A"

Position of AAA :- Accorded
Position of T.S :- Sanctioned
Project Authority :- Under UT Capex Road Sector (New Works) 2025-26.

1	Date of Issue of Tender Notice	24-06-2026
2	Period of downloading of bidding documents	From 24-06-2026 to 15-07-2026
3	Date, Time and place of pre-bid meeting	27-06-2026 at 1300 Hrs. in the Office of Executive Engineer PWD (R&B) Division Vijaypur
4	Bid submission Start Date	24-06-2026 at 1800 Hrs
5	Bid Submission End Date	15-07-2026 upto 1700 Hrs
6	Date & time of opening of Technical Bids (Online)	16-07-2026 on or after 1300 Hrs in the Office of Executive Engineer PWD (R&B) Division Vijaypur
7	Date & time of opening of Financial Bids (Online)	To be notified after technical bid evaluation is completed

The tender is available at website <http://jktenders.gov.in> all other terms & conditions can be seen on the above website.

No. PWD/V/2024-30
Dt. 24-06-2026

DIP No:DIP/J-4413/26

Sd/-
Executive Engineer,
PWD (R&B) Division,
Vijaypur

e-Tender Notice

Supereintending Engineer (PMGSY)

M. R. R. D. A, Chh. Sambhajinagar Region,

e-Tender Notice No. 23/2024-25 (Nanded) 4th call Retender

Upgradation of roads Nanded talukas of Nanded district under the Chief Minister Gram Sadak Yojana-Tappa-2 (Batch-1) 2024-25 Research and Development Program (R & D) Under Package No RD-NDD-A086 (Total No. of Works-09) for road works and 10 years maintenance repair works e Tender dated 25-06-2026 at 11.00 AM. From 01-07-2026 till 17.30 PM is being published on the website <http://mahatenders.gov.in>

Note :- Further notification & Clarification will be published on website

Sd/-
(Krushna S.Mate)
Executive Engineer (PMGSY)
M. R. R. D. A., Nanded

Dgpr/2026/27/1313

Sd/-
(Vinod Bhadane)
Suprintending Engineer (PMGSY)
M. R. R. D. A, Chh. Sambhajinagar

Rising temps expose the lack of cooling infrastructure across the continent

LONDON/PARIS/MADRID: At break time on Wednesday at the Harris Primary Academy Mayflower in Chafford Hundred, just east of London, children sucked on ice lollies and splashed about in paddling pools to cool down.

“I feel more cool and airy,” Advikhaa, 11, said of the special measures, which also include allowing children to swap their school uniforms for lighter clothing, that aim to make the high temperatures easier to bear.

While her school has found short-term fixes to alleviate the heat, thousands of others across Europe have resorted to sending pupils home during the deadly, record-breaking heatwave gripping the continent.

With such episodes becoming more frequent and intense, many schools are not able to adequately protect children from the heat.

Around 1,000 schools across England and Wales



People walk at Trocadero plaza near Eiffel Tower

have shuttered or shortened the school day, while authorities said attendance had dropped at those remaining open as parents keep children at home. French Education Minister Edouard Gecfray said that 13,500 schools were closed or placed on special schedules on Thursday due to the heat.

Relatively few schools in Europe are equipped with air

conditioning systems, leaving classrooms sweltering as temperatures peak.

British teaching union NASUWT said several of its members passed out in class on Tuesday when temperatures rose to 40 degrees Celsius (104 degrees Fahrenheit) in certain classrooms particularly exposed to the sun.

“Schools are simply not

In Short

» Teachers in France were resorting to makeshift solutions to mitigate the heat

» Relatively few schools in Europe are equipped with air conditioning systems, leaving classrooms sweltering as temperatures peak

» British teaching union NASUWT said several members passed out

equipped to deal with these kinds of temperatures,” said Wayne Bates, NASUWT’s national lead for health and safety.

Teachers in France were resorting to makeshift solutions to mitigate the heat. Some taped emergency blankets to windows or used screwdrivers to pry open those stuck shut and brought their own fans and

misting sprays to school, said Sophie Vénéttay, general secretary of SNES-FSU, the main union representing French middle and high school staff. The video player is currently playing an ad. You can skip the ad in 5 sec with a mouse or keyboard

High classroom temperatures have a direct impact on learning, researchers have found. A 2019 study published in the journal Building and Environment concluded that lowering the temperature of a classroom from 30 C to 20 C improved performance by 20%.

Paul-Emile Perret-Porret, 17, a high school student in Paris, said his parents booked an air-conditioned hotel room for him the night before his baccalauréat — France’s critical school-leaving exam — so he could get a good night’s sleep.

“If you can’t sleep the night before the exam, the heat makes it even worse. So it’s great to spend the night in air conditioning and be in good shape,” he said. **AGENCIES**

EDITORIAL
LEGAL STATUS

The Ministry of External Affairs' clarification that an Indian passport is a "travel document" and not a "citizenship document" has generated widespread public debate. For many Indians, the statement appears counter-intuitive. After all, a passport is among the most difficult documents to obtain. It requires police verification, scrutiny of personal details and is accepted globally as proof of identity and nationality. It therefore seems natural to assume that possession of an Indian passport conclusively establishes Indian citizenship. Legally, however, the issue is more nuanced. The clarification comes amid heightened attention to electoral roll verification and citizenship documentation, making it necessary to distinguish between nationality, identity and citizenship. While the controversy has acquired political overtones, it also offers an opportunity to understand the architecture of India's citizenship laws and why different documents serve different legal purposes.

Under international law, a passport is essentially a travel document issued by a sovereign state requesting foreign governments to permit the holder to travel and receive protection abroad. The Indian Passport Act, 1967, primarily governs the issuance of passports for overseas travel. Although an Indian passport is issued only to Indian nationals, its principal function is not to adjudicate citizenship disputes but to facilitate international mobility. This distinction exists because passport authorities generally rely upon documents submitted by applicants rather than conducting an independent legal determination of citizenship in every case. If fraudulent documents are used or new evidence subsequently emerges, a passport can be cancelled. Therefore, while a passport carries a strong presumption that its holder is an Indian citizen, it is not regarded as the final legal authority whenever citizenship itself is under judicial or statutory examination. This is why the government argues that a passport cannot automatically override procedures prescribed under other laws dealing specifically with citizenship or electoral eligibility.

The legal foundation of citizenship in India lies elsewhere. Articles 5 to 11 of the Constitution laid down the initial framework at the commencement of the Republic, while the Citizenship Act, 1955, subsequently became the principal legislation governing acquisition and termination of citizenship through birth, descent, registration, naturalisation and incorporation of territory. Whether an individual is an Indian citizen ultimately depends upon satisfying the conditions prescribed under this law rather than possessing any single document. In practice, citizenship may be established through a combination of birth records, family lineage, domicile history, official registers and other documentary evidence, depending upon the context in which the question arises. Courts have consistently emphasised that documentary evidence must be evaluated in its entirety rather than in isolation. Consequently, there is no single universal "citizenship certificate" issued to every Indian by default, unlike in some countries where national identity cards directly certify citizenship.

This legal complexity often confuses citizens because several government-issued documents perform different functions. An Aadhaar card establishes identity and residence but explicitly does not confer citizenship. A voter identity card establishes electoral registration but errors in electoral rolls are not unknown. A Permanent Account Number (PAN) serves taxation purposes. Birth certificates establish birth details but do not necessarily determine citizenship in every circumstance, especially after legislative amendments governing citizenship by birth. A passport occupies another category altogether: it certifies nationality for international travel but is not intended to function as the sole determinant in legal disputes over citizenship. This layered documentation system reflects India's administrative evolution rather than any deliberate attempt to create ambiguity. Yet it also highlights the need for citizens to understand that government documents are purpose-specific, each designed to meet distinct statutory objectives.

The present debate has assumed significance because it intersects with electoral processes. During voter list revisions, authorities may seek documentary evidence to establish eligibility under election laws. The Election Commission operates under a separate constitutional and statutory framework that empowers it to prepare and revise electoral rolls. Whether a passport should be treated as sufficient evidence in such exercises is therefore not merely an administrative question but one involving interpretation of multiple laws. The government's position suggests that election authorities are entitled to seek additional evidence where necessary. Critics argue that this may impose unnecessary burdens upon genuine citizens who already possess government-issued passports. The challenge lies in balancing two legitimate objectives: protecting the integrity of electoral rolls while ensuring that eligible citizens are not subjected to excessive documentary hurdles. Public confidence ultimately depends not only upon the law itself but also upon transparent, uniform and non-arbitrary implementation.

The larger lesson extends beyond the present controversy: India has rapidly expanded its digital governance architecture, issuing Aadhaar numbers, passports, voter cards, driving licences and numerous other identity documents. Yet the absence of a single universally recognised proof of citizenship continues to generate confusion whenever legal questions arise. Rather than treating the passport controversy merely as a political dispute, policymakers should view it as an opportunity to improve public awareness and administrative coherence. Citizens deserve clear communication on the legal purpose of each document, the circumstances in which additional evidence may be required and the safeguards available against wrongful exclusion. A passport undoubtedly remains one of the strongest indicators of Indian nationality, but citizenship, in law, rests upon statutory entitlement rather than possession of any one document. The objective should not be to diminish the value of the passport but to ensure that every Indian clearly understands the legal architecture governing citizenship, identity and democratic participation.

OVERDUE
REFORM



KDP RAO

THE WRITER
IS A FORMER
ADDITIONAL CHIEF
SECRETARY OF
CHHATTISGARH

The PPI facilitates a comprehensive approach by including services such as banking, telecom, insurance, transport, construction activity, and the complete production chain

India's New Inflation Compass

Transition from WPI to PPI promises a more accurate picture of producer inflation, but success will depend on robust data, institutional capacity and a carefully managed rollout

Introducing a major reform in economic indicators, India is transitioning from the Wholesale Price Index (WPI) to the Producer Price Index (PPI), launching on June 15, 2026. Nevertheless, a revised WPI with the base year 2022-23 will run in parallel with the PPI for about five years to facilitate adaptation by contracts and users. The WPI measures average price fluctuations at the wholesale level as the key producer-side inflation gauge concerning primary articles, fuel, and manufactured products, but it excludes services, which constitute a major portion of India's GDP. On the other hand, the PPI measures prices received by domestic producers for their output—goods and services—covering both input and output perspectives. As one of the global best practices, the PPI is believed to align better with modern economic structures and international standards, as reflected in the UN System of National Accounts and IMF recommendations. Secondly, it will bring clarity to industry-specific inflation trends and their transmission to consumers so that businesses can make rational pricing decisions and governments can roll out targeted monetary and fiscal policies. However, whether the transition from the WPI, which has until now been heavily relied upon by all, can be a smooth affair remains an important concern.

The PPI facilitates a comprehensive approach by including services such as banking, telecom, insurance, transport, construction activity, and the complete production chain. It reflects actual production costs by using basic prices, excluding indirect taxes, transport margins, and trade margins. It also helps reduce tax illusion, i.e., tax hikes inflating the index, and addresses the problem of double-counting intermediate goods. The PPI is seen as a better index that estimates GDP more accurately and also provides advance warnings on inflationary trends, input-output transmission, and supply-side dynamics, helping develop detailed insights into price changes across different stages of production.

However, the transition can be very challenging, as there are a number of gaps with regard to proper estimation in the production and services sectors. To begin with, many long-term projects, contracts, and government tenders that are currently dependent on the WPI may be affected by disruptions if timely and necessary adjustments are not made by both businesses and policymakers. The Department of Expenditure needs to issue the necessary guidelines. Secondly, in order to ensure a robust PPI, especially for services, extensive and reli-



Most developed economies are already using the PPI as their primary producer-level inflation measure

able data collection is required, involving detailed surveys, capacity building, and a foolproof methodology. For example, in the informal sector, which constitutes a large portion of the services economy, data collection can be a real challenge. Likewise, building robust and timely price data for diverse producers requires new surveys and improved data management, with the risk of volatility, revisions, or biases. The process is long-drawn because, while the PPI system calls for huge investments in data infrastructure, the full benefits, such as the deflation of GDP, will take a long time to materialise.

The PPI is being introduced only in seven services in the first phase, primarily in organised, data-driven sectors, namely banking, securities transactions, insurance, management of pension funds, railways, air passenger services, and telecom. As such, the trial could be successful, but the coverage will be limited. Other major service sectors such as healthcare, education, IT, real estate, hospitality, and logistics will pose challenges, as they also encompass the informal sector, where data accuracy can be an issue. The PPI may also indicate varying inflation trends due to the inclusion of services and the exclusion of imports, which can affect public perception, wage negotiations, or policy responses until users adapt to the new framework. Economists say that, at the end of the day, even though the WPI is being replaced by the PPI, the Consumer Price Index (CPI) inflation will continue to remain a separate indicator, since the PPI mainly reflects producer-side price changes. The PPI may be promising, but the above limitations could create bizarre situations if

not addressed appropriately.

Most developed economies and several G20 countries are already using the PPI as their primary producer-level inflation measure instead of the Wholesale Price Index. China, Japan, Germany, France and other European Union countries, the United Kingdom, Canada, and Australia transitioned from the WPI to the PPI long ago. Interestingly, the United States effectively replaced the WPI with the PPI in the 1970s. The US Bureau of Labour Statistics (BLS) had published the Wholesale Price Index from 1902 until 1978, after which it was renamed and reframed as the Producer Price Index, reflecting a shift in conceptual focus towards prices received by producers rather than wholesale transactions. However, the core methodology has gradually evolved over time and is now highly comprehensive, covering goods, services, construction, and many other sectors.

The transition was never easy. Several countries faced rough weather in developing, expanding, or relying on the Producer Price Index, particularly with respect to data collection, coverage (especially services), quality adjustments, respondent burden, and integration into national accounts. These issues can be even more pronounced in developing economies. Advanced economies have dealt with them through iterative improvements, expanded data sources, and internationally accepted methodologies such as the IMF Producer Price Index Manual and Eurostat-OECD guides. For example, the United States faced issues such as respondent burden and cooperation in surveys, maintaining representative samples amid rapid product differentiation,

index publication gaps when sample sizes or price quotations fell below thresholds, and transitioning aggregation systems, such as moving from the Stage-of-Processing system to the Final Demand-Intermediate Demand system in 2014. These challenges were addressed through increased use of alternative and non-traditional data sources, such as administrative databases for financial services, purchased datasets, sophisticated quality-adjustment methods, regular sample rotations, detailed industry classifications (NAICS), and ongoing methodological refinements by the BLS.

In the European Union, services are heterogeneous, consumed during production, and difficult to price consistently. Moreover, rapid product evolution required regular quality adjustments. Besides, cross-country comparability and coverage gaps in smaller or more diverse economies posed significant challenges. The EU addressed these issues through dedicated Eurostat-OECD methodological guides for the Services Producer Price Index (SPPI), incorporating best practices for pricing methods, electronic data collection, business registers for sampling, and hybrid approaches, such as combining surveys with administrative data. Special task forces and harmonised frameworks across member states were also created to improve timeliness and consistency. China and other developing countries experienced problems similar to those encountered by Western economies, and these were addressed through the gradual expansion of coverage, integration with national accounts, and policy responses based on PPI signals, such as capacity cuts to manage deflation or inflation. Administrative and enterprise data above certain thresholds were relied upon, with assumptions made for smaller units.

None of the countries achieved a perfect PPI without trial and error. Sustained investment in statistical and digital infrastructure, methodological evolution, and stakeholder adaptation were instrumental in making the PPI a success in these countries. In the Indian context, phased implementation with parallel runs, as is being rolled out from June 15, 2026, is a thoughtful measure to ensure a smooth transition. Additionally, international technical assistance from the IMF and the World Bank, along with the adoption of the SNA 2008 standards, will be of great help. Prioritising the core sectors and gradually expanding to others, coupled with considerable investments in digital reporting, administrative data, and capacity building, can ensure a complete and successful transition.

Views expressed are personal

BHARAT
KI SOCH



ABHISHEK ANAND

THE WRITER IS A
SENIOR RESEARCH
FELLOW AT BHARAT
KI SOCH

The Nalanda ruins deserve more than admiration and wonder. They deserve public respect in action

Our Monuments, Our Responsibility

India's monuments need more than legal protection. They require citizens who see heritage not as somebody else's responsibility, but as a shared inheritance demanding everyday care

A visit to the Nalanda Mahavihara – the splendid ancient Indian university and a UNESCO World Heritage Site – left me in shock and sadness. Walking through it, one does not merely see the physical structure. One encounters the historical memory of a melting pot of teaching and learning, creation and exchange of ideas, intellectual refinement, growth of the critical faculties of mind and overall human development. It is a strong reminder that Bharat's heritage of shared spaces was built by a civilisational ethos of care, patience and responsibility. That is why it was painful to see packets of eatables, wrappers, discarded plastic bottles, used tissue papers and other non-biodegradable waste strewn at a few spots.

This exposes not merely negligence, but a deeper civic failure. The Indian Constitution delineates and recognises the duty to conserve historical monuments and the ASI protects more than 3,650 monuments and historic-cultural sites. Yet, littering at them shows that laws alone cannot preserve what the citizens do not value. Ancient Indians Valued, Protected and Preserved their Civic Spaces

Interestingly, the classical Indian thought repeatedly emphasised shared responsibility toward public spaces. The Manusmriti (9.282-83) instructs:

स द्वौ कार्ष्णीणी दवादकेयं वासु शोभेयत् ॥२८२॥
अप्यन्तरीज्यं वा दूदो नर्मिणी बाल एव वा ।
परिमाणमर्हति तच्च शोभयिषि रिति ॥ २८३॥
विकिरसकानां सर्वेषां भित्ता प्रवर्त्ता दम् ।

"Anyone who drops filth on a royal highway, except in an emergency, should pay a fine of two Karshapanas and promptly clean up that filth; but if it was an individual with an emergency, an old man, a pregnant woman, or a child, that person merits a reprimand and should be made to clean it up – that is the settled rule."



Preserving India's monuments requires not only laws, but also belongingness, civic discipline and everyday responsibility

This verse directly addresses fouling of public thoroughfares. It underscores a broader ethic: public resources are not without custodians; they are owned and to be looked after by the masses. It imposes both a monetary fine and a personal obligation to clean up, embodying collective responsibility in legal form. Notably, it finds parallels in other scriptures too, such as the Vishnu Smriti (5.106-107).

Littering as Civic Indifference
Littering at a monument is often dismissed as a minor offence, a simple act of carelessness. But it is a visible expression of public apathy. It is not just about waste; it is a statement that the space does not matter enough to be respected.

This is particularly troubling at heritage sites, where visitors often fail to consider the fragility of that space. Archaic structures, exposed remains, excavation zones etc., can be damaged by accumulated waste, moisture retention and poor sanitation. Nayanjot Lahiri, the eminent historian and archaeologist, argues in her work "Monuments Matter: India's Archaeological Heritage Since Independence" (2017) that Indian heritage sites suffer not only from structural decay, but from a chronic failure of public responsibility, encompassing neglect, littering, vandalism and the routine misuse of protected spaces.

What makes this behaviour more alarming is that the litterers do not litter their homes. This is a psychological split: personal space is protected, public space is neglected. A monument becomes "someone else's responsibility"! It is a flawed notion because heritage cannot survive when public ownership is interpreted as moral abandonment.

Heritage as Collective Memory
A monument is not merely a tourist attraction, but a living record of who we were and what we valued. Nalanda represents a civilisational ethos of inquiry, debate and disciplined scholarship. Preserving cultural heritage extends beyond tourism. The UNESCO World Heritage Convention (1972) clearly delineated that monuments serve as "anchors of identity, continuity and knowledge transmission".

Bharat's constitutional framework mirrors this spirit. Article 51A imposes a fundamental duty on citizens to value and preserve heritage, while Article 49 directs the State to protect monuments from disfigurement. We must remember that when we litter the monuments, we break not only civic law but a long-standing cultural ethic of custodianship.

Discipline Needs Awareness
A clean heritage space cannot be maintained solely through

punishment. Penalties, barriers, security personnel and waste bins are necessary, but insufficient. The deeper solution lies in awareness, compassion and a sense of belonging. Indian heritage scholarship supports this belief. Himanshu Prabha Ray, the famed archaeologist who served as the first Chairperson of India's National Monuments Authority, propounds in her edited work "Decolonising Heritage in South Asia: the Global, the National and the Transnational" (2018) that sustainable preservation depends ultimately on how deeply communities internalise their relationship with heritage. I believe that if citizens truly feel that a monument belongs to them – not just legally, but ethically – their conduct shall change. They shall begin to see littering not as a trivial act but as a betrayal of shared inheritance.

The Cost of Neglect
The damage caused by littering is not only aesthetic. Waste attracts further waste. Once a site begins to look neglected, public apathy deteriorates further. A clean place invites care; a dirty place invites more dirt. This spiral effect can normalise broader disrespect. Urban studies scholars James Q. Wilson and George L. Kelling articulated this idea in their research paper "Broken Windows" (1982) through the "Broken Windows Theory", which posits that visible disorder in public spaces encourages further disorder, ultimately leading to cumulative degradation.

There are also tangible costs of littering the monuments: cleanup burden, strain on site maintenance, reduced visitor experience and the risk that archaeological surroundings will be compromised by unmanaged waste. It sends a wrong message: that we admire our heritage in thought and word, but dishonour it in practice.

Belongingness as the Real Solution
What our nation needs is not only discipline in the narrow sense

of rule-following. It needs a profound awakening of belongingness. Research works have demonstrated that a citizen who feels they belong to a civilisation does not behave like a temporary consumer of a heritage space. Rather, they feel accountable to the collective memory embedded in it. This sense of belongingness can be cultivated through public messaging, local stewardship, school curricula, volunteer programs, visitor education and visible examples from respected institutions and community leaders.

The best heritage conservation is not merely protective; it is participatory. When local communities – all – feel a sense of responsibility, a site becomes more than a protected zone. It becomes a shared moral project. This is all the more urgent in a country like ours, where heritage spaces are abundant, varied and deeply interwoven with the living communities. Preservation cannot remain the sole responsibility of the authorities.

Conclusion
The litter at a monument should disturb us not only because it is ugly, but also because it underlines that public apathy toward historical monuments is a form of civilisational amnesia. It screams that we want the prestige of heritage without the rigour of preserving it. It should prompt us to ask what kind of inheritance we intend to leave behind. What is needed is a deeper ethic: discipline, awareness, compassion, care and belongingness, all working together.

The Nalanda ruins deserve more than admiration and wonder. They deserve public respect in action. Our best etiquette should surround its remnants, not our indifference or callousness. This sentiment is also rooted in the fundamental duties of Indian citizenry that we must now start taking seriously.

Views expressed are personal

Amazon CEO meets Modi, co adds \$13 billion to AI & cloud infra plan

Fresh investment reflects Amazon’s long-term commitment to India, which Jassy described as one of the most important growth markets

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Amazon will invest an additional \$13 billion in India, taking its planned capital commitment in the country to \$48 billion between 2026 and 2030, Chief Executive Officer Andy Jassy said on Thursday after meeting Prime Minister Narendra Modi.

The fresh investment underscores Amazon’s long-term commitment to India, which Jassy described as one of the company’s most important growth markets globally.

He said Amazon’s India business is seeing strong momentum, driven by robust customer demand across e-commerce and Amazon Web Services (AWS), its cloud-computing division.

The announcement comes as global technology firms step up investments in India, attracted by the country’s expanding digital economy, growing consumer base and rising demand for cloud and AI services.

Amazon has invested heavily in India over the past decade, building out logistics networks, technology infrastructure and digital services as it seeks to deepen its presence in one of the world’s fastest-growing major economies.



Prime Minister Narendra Modi during a meeting with Amazon CEO Andy Jassy

Jassy affirmed Amazon’s long-term commitment to the country, and said the company’s India business is on a strong growth trajectory with robust customer demand, especially in e-commerce and AWS, its cloud computing unit. He also highlighted the growing importance of India, a market where Amazon operates several businesses, including e-commerce, AI, cloud, and entertainment.

“A great meeting with Mr. Andy Jassy. I welcome Amazon’s record \$48 billion investment in India. This will create new

opportunities for our youth,” Prime Minister Modi said in a post on X. This also reflects the growing interest across the world to invest in India, he said.

Sharing a photo from his meeting with the Prime Minister, Jassy, in a post on X, said he really enjoyed the discussion about what’s ahead for Amazon in India. “We’ve been serving customers, sellers, developers, startups, and enterprises in India for more than a decade and just getting started...Excited about what’s ahead. Still early days for what we can build,”

Highlights

- » He said Amazon’s India business is seeing strong momentum, driven by robust customer demand across e-commerce & Amazon Web Services
- » ‘Co’s India biz is on a strong growth trajectory with robust customer demand, especially in e-commerce & AWS’
- » By 2030, Amazon plans to support 3.8 million jobs, enable \$80 billion in e-commerce exports

Jassy said.

The Amazon top boss discussed the company’s plans to invest \$48 billion over the coming five years, including more than \$21 billion in AI and cloud infrastructure.

By 2030, Amazon plans to support 3.8 million jobs, enable \$80 billion in e-commerce exports, and bring the benefits of AI to 15 million small businesses and four million government school students, Amazon’s top executive said. The company, in a statement, said that during his meeting with the PM,

Jassy reiterated Amazon’s long-term commitment to India and announced plans to invest an additional \$13 billion to expand AI and cloud infrastructure in the country by 2030.

The latest investment pledge positions Amazon as one of the largest global AI and cloud infrastructure investors in India, the US-headquartered e-commerce giant added. “The investment will expand AWS data centre capacity in Mumbai and Hyderabad, giving startups, enterprises and government organisations access to custom AI chips, managed AI services, secure and reliable cloud technologies and developer tools to innovate faster, scale rapidly, and serve customers globally,” according to Amazon.

With this, Amazon’s cumulative investments in India exceed \$88 billion between 2010 and 2030. Just six months back, Amazon had announced \$35 billion in new India investments. “The latest investment makes Amazon one of the largest global AI and cloud infrastructure investors in India, in addition to being the largest foreign investor in India, the largest enabler of ecommerce exports and one of the biggest job creators in the country,” Amazon said.

‘Hub & Spoke flights to connect regions to global opportunities’

Hub & Spoke model seeks to enable seamless connectivity between Tier-II, Tier-III airports with int’l locations

OUR CORRESPONDENT

VARANASI: Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Thursday said the Hub and Spoke international flights model will reduce travel time for passengers as well as being regions of India closer to global opportunities.

The Hub and Spoke model seeks to enable seamless connectivity between Tier-II and Tier-III airports with international destinations.

Under this model, Air India on Thursday launched flight operations from Varanasi that will connect passengers to various overseas cities through Delhi. Describing the launch of the first Hub and Spoke international flight operations as a historic milestone, Modi said better international connectivity creates new opportunities for trade, tourism, investment, education and business. “It enables people from smaller cities to access global destinations through a single, integrated journey while also supporting the movement of goods and services. This will contribute to regional development and strengthen India’s economic growth,” he said in a message.

The message was read out by Civil Aviation Secretary Samir Kumar Sinha at the inaugural ceremony for the first flight under the model that will be operated by Air India from the Varanasi airport.



Prime Minister Narendra Modi

Under this model, Air India on launched flight operations from Varanasi that will connect passengers to various overseas cities through Delhi

According to the prime minister, the initiative will reduce travel time for passengers, make better use of existing infrastructure, improve aircraft utilisation and help ease congestion at major airports.

“Most importantly, it will bring more regions of India closer to global opportunities,” he said. The message signed by the prime minister was also displayed at the airport.

Varanasi, from where the operations under the model are starting, is also the Lok Sabha constituency represented by Modi. “One of the world’s old-

Key Points

- » Modi said better global connectivity creates new opportunities for trade, tourism, investment, education and business
- » ‘It enables people from smaller cities to access global destinations through a single, integrated journey while also supporting goods & services movement
- » ‘This will contribute to regional development and strengthen India’s economic growth,’ the prime minister said in a message

est living cities and a symbol of India’s rich civilisational heritage, Varanasi represents the spirit of our vision of taking Vikas and Virasat together. Improved connectivity will further strengthen its links with the world while preserving its unique identity,” he said in the message. Passengers arriving from smaller cities will be routed through major hub airports such as Delhi for onward international connections. Outbound flights will carry both originating domestic passengers and international transit passengers.

Rupee rises 10 paise to 94.45 against dollar

MUMBAI: The rupee appreciated 10 paise to settle at 94.45 against the US dollar on Thursday as global crude oil prices continued to slide.

Positive sentiments in the domestic equity markets and a marginally weaker greenback further supported the local unit while Foreign Institutional Investors (FIIs) outflows prevented sharper gains, forex traders said.

At the interbank foreign exchange, the rupee opened at 94.30 against the dollar and traded in the range of 94.13-94.56.

It settled at 94.45, up 10 paise from the previous close.

The rupee appreciated 21 paise to settle at 94.55 against the US dollar on Wednesday.

“The rupee strengthened on falling commodity prices and softening of the US dollar. Weakness in crude oil prices and positive domestic markets also favoured the rupee,” Anuj Choudhary, Research Analyst, Mirae Asset ShareKhan, said.

“We expect the rupee to trade with a negative bias on overall strength in the US dollar on hawkish Federal Reserve. However, softening of commodity prices and easing concerns over inflation may support the rupee at lower levels,” Choudhary said, adding that the rupee is expected to trade in the range of 94.20-94.80.

Meanwhile, the dollar index, which gauges the greenback’s strength against a basket of six currencies, was trading at 101.57, lower by 0.04 per cent.

DoT invites telecom authorisation & licence migration applications

Applicants can now submit their applications online through the ‘Telecom eServices Portal’

NEW DELHI: Department of Telecom (DoT) has begun accepting applications for telecommunication service authorisation, as well as for migration of existing licences to the terms and conditions of authorisation, an official release said on Thursday.

The move comes within days of the Government notifying a set of rules that operationalise a new authorisation-based framework in India’s telecom sector, marking a transition from the legacy licensing regime.

“The Department of Telecommunications (DoT) has officially commenced the

acceptance of applications for obtaining authorisations for providing telecommunication services, as well as for the migration of existing licences to the terms and conditions of authorisation under the Telecommunications Act, 2023,” the release said.

As laid out under the Telecommunications Act, 2023, the provisions of the authorisation rules are being implemented using the ‘digital by design’ principle.

“To facilitate this, application modules for both obtaining a fresh authorisation and migrating existing licences

have been made operational,” the release said.

Applicants can now submit their applications online through the ‘Telecom eServices Portal’.

The telecom department had, as an interim measure, suspended the acceptance of new applications for issuing Unified Licences, Unified Licence (VNO), Standalone Licences, Registrations, Permissions, and No Objection Certificates with effect from November 10, 2025.

The suspension was put in place pending the notification of the new authorisation framework.

Anil Ambani moves NCLAT, appeals against initiation of personal insolvency by NCLT

NEW DELHI: Industrialist Anil Ambani has moved the National Company Law Appellate Tribunal (NCLAT) against an National Company Law Tribunal (NCLT) order initiating personal insolvency proceedings against him on a petition filed by State Bank of India.

The Mumbai bench of the NCLT had on June 11 admitted SBI’s plea seeking personal insolvency proceedings against Ambani over loan defaults by Reliance Communications (RCOM) and Reliance Infratel Ltd (RITL), for which he had furnished personal guarantees.

Ambani’s appeal came up before a two-member NCLAT bench of Justice Mohd Faiz



Alam Khan and Barun Mitra. The matter will now be heard on July 10. SBI had filed an application under Section 95 of the Insolvency & Bankruptcy Code (IBC), claiming a default of about Rs 853.25 crore as of March 1, 2019, arising from personal guarantees executed by Ambani for loans extended to RCOM and RITL.

The lender argued that approval of resolution plans for the two companies did not extinguish its rights against the personal guarantor. It also relied on a Resolution Professional’s report under Section 99 of the IBC, which concluded that the debt and default were established and that the guarantees remained enforceable. Ambani challenged the findings, contending that the guarantee stood discharged after approval of RCOM’s resolution plan. He also alleged that the Resolution Professional’s report violated principles of natural justice.

Rejecting his objections, the NCLT held that the guarantee was not rendered invalid

merely because it was executed after the loan account became a non-performing asset, noting that the NPA classification was retrospective and followed a restructuring exercise.

The tribunal also recorded SBI’s contention that multiple applications filed by Ambani over the years had delayed the insolvency proceedings. A spokesperson for Ambani said the case relates to a disputed guarantee allegedly extended in 2016, before personal insolvency provisions came into force, and that the underlying loan was used by RCOM to repay borrowings from Chinese lenders, yielding no personal benefit to Ambani.

NEW DELHI: The Railway Ministry has decided to amend its existing policies to allow industries to design freight wagons according to their specific requirements.

Railway Minister Ashwini Vaishnaw held a review meeting on Thursday with senior officials to undertake comprehensive reforms in the existing Wagon Design Policy to make it more attractive for various industries.

The move is aimed at attracting new freight streams, enhancing customer convenience, and significantly increasing the rail share in the national logistics sector, the minister said.

“Indian Railways is engaging

in extensive consultations with various industries, trade bodies, and major freight customers associated with commodities that have significant potential for rail transportation,” a press note from the railway ministry said.

“During these discussions, industry representatives suggested that if wagon designs are customized according to the specific handling, loading, unloading, and transportation requirements of different commodities, rail transport could be adopted on a much wider scale,” it read.

Officials said Vaishnaw during the review meeting directed officials to finalise

the new Wagon Design Policy within 15 days with an industry-friendly framework for the development of specialised wagons tailored to the needs of different commodities.

The review meeting also highlighted the success of recently-developed specialised wagons for commodities such as cement and salt that has demonstrated the importance of designing wagons in accordance with industry operational requirements.

“Commodity-specific wagons have improved loading, unloading, and transportation efficiency, thereby enhancing the attractiveness of rail logistics,” the ministry said.

Adani Foundation marks Adani’s 64th birthday with blood donation drive

AHMEDABAD: The Adani Foundation marked Adani Group Chairman Gautam Adani’s 64th birthday on June 24 with a nationwide blood donation drive that collected a record 52,306 units of blood, surpassing last year’s tally of 28,090 units.

The initiative was conducted in partnership with more than 764 blood banks across over 754 cities in 21 states, five Union Territories and four international locations. Supported by the Adani Healthcare team, the campaign mobilised thousands of donors and over 6,000 volunteers.

According to the Founda-

tion, the drive collected around 23,538 litres of blood, which is expected to benefit more than 1.56 lakh patients. The blood will help provide critical components such as packed red cells, platelets, plasma, fresh frozen plasma and cryoprecipitate, used in emergency care, surgeries, cancer treatment, maternal healthcare and management of chronic illnesses.

Dr Priti Adani, Chairperson of the Adani Foundation, said the initiative reflected Gautam Adani’s belief that “Seva Hi Sadhana Hai” (service is worship). In a post on X, she thanked Adani Group employees and medical professionals for their

contribution, saying the drive would bring hope and strength to more than 1.56 lakh patients and their families.

The campaign was organised in collaboration with Red Cross blood banks, government hospitals and trust-run blood banks. Volunteers, including doctors, paramedics and administrative personnel, helped ensure its smooth execution. Launched in 2011 with just over 1,300 units collected, the annual drive has grown into one of India’s largest voluntary blood donation initiatives, bringing together employees, partners and communities in support of a common cause.

NEW DELHI: Infrastructure projects worth above Rs 150 crore each registered a cumulative cost overrun of around Rs 5.4 lakh crore, according to a monthly government report for May 2026.

A total of 1,987 ongoing infrastructure projects across 17 Central Ministries/Departments were monitored and it was found that the total revised cost was Rs 42.50 lakh crore compared to their original cost of Rs 37.09 lakh crore.

The report, however, did not specify the actual number of projects that faced cost overrun. The cumulative expendi-

CLOSER LOOK

- » A total of 1,987 ongoing infra projects were monitored and it was found that the total revised cost was Rs 42.50 lakh crore against original cost of Rs 37.09 lakh crore
- » The transport & logistics sector accounts for the highest number of ongoing projects (1,476 projects), with revised estimates of Rs 23.50 lakh crore

ture incurred on these projects stands at Rs 21.82 lakh crore, accounting for approximately 51.34 per cent of the revised project cost, as per a statement by Ministry of Statistics and Programme Implementation (MoSPI).

sector accounts for the highest number of ongoing projects (1,476 projects), with revised estimates of Rs 23.50 lakh crore.

Of the total 1,987 ongoing infrastructure projects, 813 are mega projects (project cost of Rs 1,000 crore and above) with an original cost of Rs 31.58 lakh crore, and 1,174 are major projects (Rs 1,000 crore and up to Rs 150 crore) amounting to Rs 5.52 lakh crore.

Physical and financial progress broadly move in tandem, with a large number of projects clustered at the initial (0–20 per cent) and advanced (81–100 per cent) stages, indicating a

pipeline of newly-started projects alongside many nearing completions.

Ministry of Road Transport & Highways accounts for the highest number of projects, with 1,149 projects (58 per cent), and a share of total revised project cost of Rs 10.95 lakh crore (26 per cent), highlighting its central role in national infrastructure development.

Ministry of Railways is implementing 261 projects, with a total revised project cost of Rs 8.79 lakh crore. Ministry of Coal is implementing 121 projects, with a total revised project cost of Rs 2.23 lakh crore.

Adani to invest ₹20K crore in Airport cities across 5 states

The development will cover airports in Mumbai, Navi Mumbai, Ahmedabad, Lucknow, Jaipur and Guwahati

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Adani Airport plans to invest more than Rs 20,000 crore in the first phase of a large-scale airport city development programme spanning over 655 acres across six airports in five states, as the company seeks to transform its aviation hubs into integrated commercial and urban destinations.

The development, announced on Thursday by Adani Airport City Ltd (AACL) - a wholly-owned subsidiary of Adani Airport Holdings Limited (AAHL), India's largest private airport operator - will cover airports in Mumbai, Navi Mumbai, Ahmedabad, Lucknow, Jaipur and Guwahati, with around 22 million square feet of mixed-use infrastructure planned in the initial phase.

Nearly 70 per cent of the investment will be concentrated in Mumbai and Navi Mumbai, where the company controls close to 440 acres of land, reflecting the strategic importance of the Mumbai Metropolitan Region as India's largest aviation and commercial hub, it said in a statement.

The projects will combine hotels, offices, retail, entertainment, convention centres and lifestyle infrastructure within



About 70 per cent of the investment will be concentrated in Mumbai and Navi Mumbai, where the company controls close to 440 acres of land

airport-linked districts designed to integrate with metro and urban transport networks.

"Airports have an opportunity to create value far beyond aviation," said Jeet Adani, Director, AAHL, adding that the developments are intended to drive investment, employment and urban growth around key aviation centres. The airport city model, widely adopted at hubs such as Singapore Changi Airport, Dubai International Airport, Amsterdam Airport Schiphol and Incheon Interna-

Highlights

- » The projects will combine hotels, offices, retail, entertainment, convention centres and lifestyle infra within airport-linked districts
- » 'Airports have an opportunity to create value far beyond aviation,' said Jeet Adani, Director, AAHL,
- » AACL has signed hotel management pacts with IHG Hotels & Resorts for five premium and luxury hotels

tional Airport, aims to generate economic activity beyond passenger traffic by creating integrated business and tourism ecosystems.

As part of the initiative, AACL has signed hotel management agreements with IHG Hotels & Resorts for five premium and luxury hotels, including the debut of the Kimpton brand in India. The company said all Airport City projects have received LEED Gold pre-certification from the US Green Building Council, underscoring

a focus on sustainable design, energy efficiency and walkable urban infrastructure.

AAHL, India's largest private airport operator, manages eight airports, including Mumbai and the upcoming Navi Mumbai International Airport. The airport city initiative forms a key part of its strategy to diversify revenue streams and capitalise on the rapid growth of India's aviation market.

The group plans to "develop integrated airport cities across its airport network, bringing together hospitality, retail, entertainment, convention and commercial infrastructure within seamlessly connected, walkable urban districts," the statement said. "The development represents an investment of more than Rs 20,000 crore in the first phase. Approximately 22 million sq. ft. will be developed across Mumbai, Navi Mumbai, Ahmedabad, Lucknow, Jaipur and Guwahati."

The developments are designed as integrated, walkable urban districts where travellers, businesses and local communities can access hotels, offices, retail, dining, entertainment and convention facilities within environments seamlessly integrated with airport, Metro and city transport infrastructure.

S&P upgrades Adani Ports & SEZ to BBB, cites strong cash flows and balance sheet strength

NEW DELHI: S&P Global Ratings on Thursday upgraded Adani Ports and Special Economic Zone (APSEZ) to investment-grade BBB from BBB-, citing its robust cash generation, strengthening balance sheet and ability to fund an ambitious expansion plan while maintaining healthy leverage.

The rating agency assigned a stable outlook on APSEZ, reflecting the expectation that the company will sustain strong operating performance over the next 12-24 months and keep its net debt-to-EBITDA ratio at around 2.6 times despite elevated capital spending.

S&P said the company's strong financial position provides significant headroom to support its growth strategy, which includes increasing domestic port capacity to 1



billion tonne by 2030 from 653 million tonne currently.

The agency expects annual capital expenditure to rise to about Rs 18,000 crore in fiscals 2027 and 2028 and Rs 20,000 crore in fiscal 2029, from historical levels of around Rs 13,000 crore. Most of the spending is expected to be directed toward expanding domestic port infrastructure, particularly container terminal capacity.

APSEZ is also pursuing international growth opportu-

nities, including in Africa and Southeast Asia, although S&P cautioned that acquisitions in markets with weaker regulatory and macroeconomic environments could affect earnings quality and increase operational risks.

The rating agency said the company's recently tightened leverage policy, which targets net debt-to-EBITDA of up to 2.5 times, supports its view that financial metrics will remain strong even as investment spending accelerates.

S&P expects earnings growth to be driven by higher capacity utilization at ports, including Vizhinjam and Colombo, along with a full-year contribution from the North Queensland Export Terminal in Australia. Cargo volumes are projected to grow about 18 per

Oil prices fall to pre-war levels, no change in petrol and diesel prices

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Global oil prices fell on Thursday to their lowest levels since before the outbreak of the Iran conflict, offering a significant economic tailwind for India, the world's third-largest crude importer, by easing inflation risks, reducing the import bill and improving the government's fiscal position.

Brent crude, the international benchmark, dropped to about \$72-73 a barrel, while US crude fell below \$70 a barrel, erasing the geopolitical risk premium that had driven prices as high as \$120 a barrel during the height of the conflict earlier this year. Both benchmarks are now back near levels last seen in late February, before hostilities disrupted Middle East energy markets.



Petrol and diesel prices had been raised by about Rs 7.50 per litre each during the recent spike in international oil prices, but state-owned fuel retailers have so far refrained from cutting pump prices

Despite the sharp fall in crude oil prices, retail fuel rates remained unchanged on Thursday. Petrol and diesel prices had been raised by about Rs 7.50 per litre each during the recent spike in international oil prices, but state-owned fuel retailers have so far refrained from cutting pump prices, according to industry data.

Officials said the three state-run fuel retailers are currently earning healthy marketing margins on petrol, although diesel sales continue to generate a modest loss. The companies had held retail prices steady for nearly two-and-a-half months despite rising global crude prices before implementing only a partial increase.

Industry officials noted that fuel prices are not adjusted based on daily movements in international crude markets but are typically guided by average oil prices over the preceding fortnight or month. As a result, any benefit from the recent correction in crude prices may take time to be reflected at the pump if lower international rates are sustained.

The easing in oil market tensions has also been reflected in the government's response. Inter-ministerial briefings that were instituted after the outbreak of the conflict have quietly been paused, signaling reduced concern over immediate energy supply disruptions.

The briefings, initially held

daily and later scaled back to twice a week, brought together officials from key ministries to update the public on the country's preparedness and management of the crisis. Officials from the Ministry of Petroleum and Natural Gas were a regular presence, outlining measures taken to safeguard fuel supplies and maintain market stability.

No briefings were held this week on the scheduled days of Monday and Thursday, underscoring the government's assessment that risks to energy supplies and trade flows have eased following the de-escalation of hostilities and the retreat in oil prices.

The basket of crude oil that India buys averaged \$71.17

per barrel on February 27 - a day before the US and Israel attacked Iran, resulting in sweeping retaliation by Tehran, which effectively shut the Strait of Hormuz that transited oil and gas from Gulf countries to user nations like India.

Indian Basket averaged \$70.71 a barrel on June 24, according to data from Oil Ministry's Petroleum Planning and Analysis Cell (PPAC).

For the month (June), the Indian basket has averaged \$86.31 per barrel as compared to \$72.47 per barrel average for February 2026.

With Brent crude now back near pre-conflict levels, pressure is likely to mount on fuel retailers and the government to pass on some of the gains to consumers, particularly if crude remains below recent highs for an extended period. Lower fuel prices could further ease inflationary pressures and support consumer spending in Asia's third-largest economy.

The decline follows a normalization of tanker traffic through the Strait of Hormuz, through which roughly one-fifth of global oil supplies pass. US officials said at least 20 million barrels transited the waterway over the past 24 hours, with flows nearing pre-war levels.

For India, which imports more than 88 per cent of its crude oil requirements, every \$10-per-barrel fall in oil prices translates into billions of dollars in annual savings on its import bill and helps narrow the current account deficit.

Gautam Adani launches search for grassroots innovators

NEW DELHI: Vande Bharatam will conduct a nationwide search for innovators, entrepreneurs and changemakers across all 36 States & UTs and more than 800 districts. Gautam Adani, Chairman of the Adani Group, launched the nationwide program on his 64th birthday. The initiative aims to bring ideas from beyond traditional startup hubs onto a national platform.

The initiative comes at a time when India ranks among the top global startup ecosystems, but more than 80 per cent of founders emerge from only five cities. To widen access, the program invites participants of all ages and educational backgrounds, from metropolitan centers to rural communities.

Applicants can submit concepts, prototypes, early-stage ventures, or established businesses without needing a registered startup.

Entries span sectors such as technology, manufacturing, sustainability, agriculture, traditional crafts, and community solutions. Dedicated pathways will encourage participation from women, tribal entrepreneurs, rural innovators, and Divyang entrepreneurs. Following structured regional evaluations, 75 finalists will attend an intensive mentorship and investment program in Ahmedabad, leading to a Grand Finale around Independence Day.

Launching the initiative, Gautam Adani said, "When I began my journey, I had nothing. Everything I am and everything I have achieved was given to me by the soil of Bharat. There is no shortage of talent in our nation, but opportunity has not always reached every corner of the country."

ANI

ONGC & BP sign technical services contract for Western Offshore Basin

NEW DELHI: ONGC and BP have signed a technical services contract for ONGC's Western Offshore Basin, expanding their partnership beyond Mumbai High to boost production from mature oil and gas fields.

Under the pact, BP will serve as Technical Services Provider for the basin, which comprises 43 blocks and is ONGC's largest producing region. ONGC will retain ownership and operational control, while BP will support reservoir management, well optimisation and production facility improvements.

The companies aim to slow production decline, enhance hydrocarbon recovery and improve operational efficiency. BP will receive a fixed fee for the first two years, followed by



a performance-linked fee tied to incremental production.

The deal builds on a technical services agreement for Mumbai High signed in February 2025. ONGC said the collaboration has already helped moderate production decline and improve output through better well optimisation and reservoir management.

ONGC Chairman & CEO Arun Kumar Singh said the expanded partnership would support higher recovery and sustained production growth. BP India Chairman & Senior Vice President Kartikeya Dube said the firm would leverage its global expertise to enhance production and strengthen India's energy security.

MPOST

'Telecom subscriber base rises to 134 cr in May, Airtel leads growth'

NEW DELHI: Telecom subscriber base grew to 134.3 crore in May, driven by net additions on the Bharti Airtel and Reliance Jio networks, according to Trai data released on Thursday.

Airtel led the growth in subscriber base with net addition of 29.8 lakh subscribers over the month of April, comprising 29.26 lakh in the mobile segment and 53,809 in fixed line connection segment.

It was followed by Reliance Jio, which reported a net addition of 22.55 lakh subscribers, comprising 21.54 lakh in the mobile segment and 1.01 lakh in the fixed line segment.

Both private telecom operators jointly contributed 52.36 lakh new subscribers, or about



94 per cent, in the total net addition of 55.6 lakh subscribers in May.

"The number of total telephone subscribers in India increased from 1,337.54 million at the end of April 2026 to 1,343.10 million at the end of May 2026, thereby showing a monthly growth rate of 0.42 per cent," Trai's monthly data subscriber report for May 2026 said.

The total number of wireless connections in May increased to 129.44 crore from 128.89 crore in April. The total wireless connections comprised 114.58 crore consumer sim, 13.11 crore M2M sim and 1.17 crore fixed wireless access connections.

As per the information filed by 1,544 operators for the month of May 2026, the total number of broadband subscribers increased to 108 crore from 107.34 crore in April.

Reliance Jio led the segment with 52.96 crore broadband subscribers. It was followed by Bharti Airtel with 37.6 crore subscribers, Vi 12.9 crore, BSNL 2.7 crore and Atria Convergence 24 lakh broadband subscribers.

PTI

Vedanta contributes ₹62,722 cr to exchequer in FY26, up 13.3%

NEW DELHI: Diversified natural resources company Vedanta Ltd on Thursday said it has contributed Rs 62,722 crore to the exchequer in the financial year 2025-26, registering an increase of 13.3 per cent over the previous year.

This contribution to the exchequer was on the back of Vedanta's historic-best financial performance in the last financial year.

According to the company's 11th tax transparency report, Vedanta's cumulative contribution to the exchequer over the past ten years was to the tune of Rs 4,83,034 crore.

"The contribution represents 36 per cent of the company's consolidated revenue from operations, playing a pivotal role in India's economic development," the company said.

The strong financial performance was driven by robust operational performance across Vedanta's diversified portfolio spanning zinc-lead-silver, aluminium, copper, iron ore, steel, power, nickel, chrome and oil and gas.

Zinc remained the largest contributor at Rs 19,053 crore, followed by Vedanta Aluminium at Rs 15,788 crore & Vedanta Oil & Gas at Rs 11,697 crore.

MPOST

'Domestic SIPs power India's mkt resilience amid foreign investment outflows'

'If you look at SIP, it has singularly been the largest driver for driving investor habit to ensure that capital comes into the markets'

MUMBAI: India's financial markets are structurally transitioning from foreign dominance into rock-solid domestic hands, successfully shielding the local economy from severe downside risks despite a prolonged three-year selling streak by Foreign Portfolio Investors (FPIs).

Unmesh Sharma, Senior Executive Vice President at HDFC Securities broke down the mechanics behind the multi-year foreign capital exodus, tracking it back to global asset allocation and recent geopolitical skirmishes.

"Look, you have to look into the reasons in the last three

years why FPIs have been selling India - the first part was actually switching into other markets because some only markets, like Korea and China, were offering better value," Sharma stated.

He added that while liquidity is fully fungible global capital, recent wars triggered a broad "risk-off globally on all risk assets" across emerging markets.

However, Sharma noted that selective buying persists where earnings visibility exists, and once adjusted against booming primary market inflows, the net outflow is much smaller than perceived.

CLOSER LOOK

- » Regular monthly systematic investment plans have turned investing into an unbreakable habit, Unmesh Sharma, Senior Executive Vice President at HDFC Securities said
- » Sharma remains fully confident that advisors have successfully educated investors to stay long-term positive on corporate India
- » He ruled out any severe risk of domestic retail capital falling off a cliff over the next 6 to 12 months

Addressing long-term Foreign Direct Investment (FDI), he explained that "FDI is higher for fixed asset technology" and will spike heavily as structural investments scale up across

wallet share of Indian domestic wealth has moved systematically into equities.

"If you look at SIP, it has singularly been the largest driver for driving investor habit to ensure that capital comes into the markets," Sharma emphasised, noting that regular monthly systematic investment plans (SIPs) have turned investing into an unbreakable habit.

Even with muted retail equity performance over the last two years, Sharma remains fully confident that advisors have successfully educated investors to stay long-term positive on corporate India.

"Right now there seems to be a lot of maturity in the Indian investor that they are actually motoring through the period to be able to do that," he observed, ruling out any severe risk of domestic retail capital falling off a cliff over the next 6 to 12 months.

Concurrently, wealthy Indian investors are aggressively utilising global asset diversification as a risk-mitigation tool to hedge against local currency risk, given the historical 4 per cent compound annual depreciation of the Rupee.

Sharma clarified that this global footprint is a strategic

portfolio decision for affluent global citizens, rather than investors "voting with their feet" out of local economic anxiety.

This global integration also highlights a canny turnaround in the nation's historical "brain drain" patterns. While advanced high-level scientific research still occurs overseas, Sharma expressed strong encouragement over the vast domestic scope available post-1991 for STEM and finance professionals to thrive directly inside India.

Turning to monetary policy, macro pressures, and the RBI's upcoming moves, Sharma struck a hawkish note.

ANI

Vini, Vidi, Vici

Vinicius scores 2 as Brazil beat Scotland to win group; Neymar returns in time

MIAMI GARDENS: Vinicius Júnior made it look easy. So did Brazil.

Vinicius scored two goals — one of them practically into an empty net to open the scoring — and five-time World Cup champion Brazil beat Scotland 3-0 on Wednesday, advancing to the knockout stage as the Group C winner.

Vinicius — who has a goal in all three of Brazil's group matches — scored in the seventh minute and again just before halftime, tying Norway's Erling Haaland and Kylian Mbappé with of France with four goals, one behind Lionel Messi of Argentina.

Matheus Cunha also scored for the Seleção, who reached the knockout rounds for the 15th consecutive World Cup. Morocco finished second in the group and also advanced, rallying to beat Haiti 4-2.

After a lackluster 1-1 draw against Morocco in its opener, Brazil — facing pressure to win its first World Cup title since 2002 — followed with a 3-0 win over Haiti, and coach Carlo Ancelotti said he saw gradual improvement from his team during the group stage.

"We are working to play the best that we can," he said. "But the goal is not to play well. We know that playing well is easier



Brazil's Vinicius Junior heads in a goal against Scotland

AP

to win, but the goal is to win. ... If we win the World Cup, we played well. If we don't win the World Cup, we played really bad."

Neymar entered as a substitute in the 76th, making his debut after a right calf injury sidelined him for Brazil's first two matches. The majority-Brazilian crowd at Hard Rock Stadium began chanting his name midway through the second half as he got off the bench and began doing warmup sprints on the sideline — and fans roared as he trotted onto

4
Neymar is just the fourth player to represent Brazil at four different WCs

the pitch.

A first for South Africa
GUADALUPE: South

Africa advanced to the knockout phase of the World Cup for the first time with a 1-0 victory over South Korea on Wednesday night.

Thapelo Maseko scored in the 63rd minute off a precise cross from Tshepang Moremi and South Africa finished in second place in Group A behind Mexico, which won all three of its group-stage games.

South Africa will take on Canada, the second-place finisher in Group B, in a knockout game Sunday at Inglewood, California. AGENCIES

Mexico advance in style

MEXICO CITY: Javier Aguirre has been saying for a while now that the key to the Mexican team's success at the World Cup is that they are a family. This family, it seems, is on a historic journey.

Mateo Chávez and Julián Quiñones scored in a six-minute span early in the second half, and Mexico beat the Czech Republic 3-0 on Wednesday to complete wins in all three of its World Cup group-stage matches for the first time.

The 22-year-old Chávez, in his first World Cup, opened the scoring in the 55th minute and Quiñones scored his second goal of the tournament in the 61st. Alvaro Fidalgo added a goal in stoppage time.

"It was something very beautiful, and I'll take it with me to the grave," Chávez said of his goal. "I imagined it many times; I dreamed of this." Mexico's previous best group-stage performance was two wins and one draw, done in 1986 and 2002. AGENCIES



Kylian Mbappe and Deschamps during a training session

AP

Finishing first would likely avoid collision with the likes of Brazil, England and Portugal

that could include Germany in the round of 16 and European champions Spain in the semi-finals.

Norway, meanwhile, have become one of the stories of the tournament. Their synchronised rowing celebration has won admirers around the world and victories over Iraq and Senegal have secured their place in the knockout rounds.

Coach Stale Solbakken's side arrive full of confidence after their 3-2 victory over Senegal, but the physical toll of that game

could prompt significant rotation against France.

Solbakken said Norway would do all they can to help Erling Haaland claim the Golden Boot, with the striker on four goals, but he may be reluctant to risk his biggest stars with qualification guaranteed.

Haaland and captain Martin Odegaard, Norway's most influential players, could be on the bench with Alexander Sorloth expected to spearhead the attack. Patrick Berg, who set up Haaland's second goal against Senegal, could slot into midfield.

Central defender Leo Ostigard has also strengthened his case for a starting role and may replace the injured Julian Ryerson Whether or not Norway rotate, France will have to contend with one of the form teams of the tournament. AGENCIES

Litchfield boost for Oz against India?

LONDON: Australia could receive a timely boost ahead of Sunday's T20 World Cup clash against India with star batter Phoebe Litchfield set to return from injury, and it could hand the six-time champions a significant edge in the high-stakes encounter.

Litchfield suffered a calf injury during the match against South Africa in Manchester earlier in the tournament

and missed the last three games, though the Aussies remained unbeaten.

Coach Shelley Nitschke indicated that Litchfield might return for Australia's final group-stage clash at Lord's against Harmanpreet Kaur's side. "I think Pheebs (Litchfield) is tracking really well and hopefully will be available for the India game," Nitschke said. AGENCIES

Fielding horror, women huff & puff to win



Shafali Verma made a 34-ball 53 against Bangladesh

BCCI

(26 off 15 balls) took India close to the finishing line.

Having lost to South Africa, India will need to beat Australia on June 28 in their bid to make the semifinals. Smriti Mandhana fell cheaply but Shafali single-handedly fired India to 63 for one in the powerplay.

The target was very gettable and Shafali provided a flying start to ensure that India got home in 16.5 overs. There was bit of lull in the middle overs before Jemimah Rodrigues

unleashing the inside out shot on multiple occasions.

She brought her second World Cup fifty off 29 balls in the eighth over, taking India on the cusp of a big win. The explosive opener was stumped in a rather unusual fashion as she went for a non-existent single after edging a ball from Nahida Akter in the ninth over, not realising the wicketkeeper had collected the ball and dislodged the stumps.

FOCUS ON SAMSON, KISHAN

Sooryavanshi dilemma as India begin Irish tour



Vaibhav Sooryavanshi starred against Sri Lanka A recently

FILE

BELFAST: Accommodating teenage sensation Vaibhav Sooryavanshi in the starting eleven will be the toughest riddle for the team management when India step into a new T20 era under Shreyas Iyer in the first of a two-match series against Ireland here on Friday. There is heightened interest surrounding Sooryavanshi's possible international debut after the 15-year-old's stunning run in the IPL and a marauding 29-ball 94 for India A against Sri Lanka A in a tri-series one-day match at Dambulla.

But according to the popular demand will not be easy for the think tank. Currently, India's top three are: Sanju Samson, Abhishek Sharma and Ishan Kishan. And their overall and recent T20 records are not easy to ignore. Samson, Abhishek and Kishan made fifties in the ICC T20 World Cup final win over New Zealand in March, which was also India's last assignment in the short-format.

If the management wants to include Sooryavanshi, an opener, then one of Samson or Abhishek will have to go down or sit out, and that is a harsh step in the aftermath of a World

If the management wants to include Sooryavanshi, an opener, then one of Samson or Abhishek will have to go down or sit out

Cup title win. The bigwigs can push Samson down to the middle-order, as he has batted at No. 4 and No. 5 in the past.

But those slots will now be taken by skipper Iyer and his deputy Tilak Varma, leaving No. 6 the only open space.

However, it traditionally belongs to an all-rounder and India have multiple choices in Shivam Dube, Washington Sundar, Axar Patel and newcomer Suryansh Shedge.

Placing Samson at No. 6 will force India to enter the field with just five bowlers, and that department already wears a thin look in the absence of Jasprit Bumrah, Mohammad Siraj and Varun Chakravathy.

Even otherwise, Samson has excellent numbers at the pole position -- 926 from 28 innings with three tons. AGENCIES

MAHARASHTRA JEEVAN PRADHIKARAN

E-Tender Notice No. 26 For 2025 – 26 (Fourth Call)

On behalf of Executive Engineer M.J.P.W.M.Division Satara invites E -Tender Notice for the work of M & R to Lashkar Water Works Tal.Dist. Satara. In the State of Maharashtra, Valued at Rs. 4,83,96,993/- .The e-Tender details are available on www.mahatenders.gov.in from dated 29/06/2026.

All relevant dates will be as per the tender published in web portal www.mahatenders.gov.in
Date :-29/06/2026

Office Phone No. 02162/221682

(Ajit Waghmare)
Executive Engineer,
M.J.P.W.M. Division, Satara.

Dgipr/2026-27/1322

NORTHERN RAILWAY

Applications are invited under scheme of 'One Station One Product' for setting up:

A. **Total Eight (08) Stall** at: Delhi, Delhi Cantt., Delhi Shahdara, Faridabad, Ghaziabad, Meerut City, Pataudi Road, Gurgaon Railway stations..

B. **Total Forty (40) Trolley** at: Ballabgarh, Bagpat Road, Baraut, Delhi Kishanganj, Delhi Sarairohilla, Faridabad New Town, Garhi Harsaru, Jakhhal, Jind, Muzzafarnagar, Julana, Narela, Khekra, Mansa, Meerut City, Nangoli, Narwana, Noli, Okhla, Palam, Shakurbasti, Shamli, Tapri, Tohana, Tughlakabad, Vivek Vihar, Asawati, Delhi Azadpur, Delhi Safadarganj, Deoband, Khatauli, Mangolpuri, Modinagar, Meerut Cantt, Muradnagar, New Ghaziabad, Partapur, Sakoti Tanda, Sampla, Shivaji Bridge, Tilak Bridge Railway Stations.

• The period for setting up of stall/Trolley at Delhi Jn., Kurukshetra, Palwal, Gurgaon, & Meerut Cantt, Narela, Rohtak, Julana, Sampla Railway Stations per spell will be 90 days.

• **Registration fee for NSG 1, 2, 3** stations will be charged @ rate of **Rs. 2000** for each spell of thirty days and for **NSG 4,5,6** (Delhi Kishanganj, Deoband, Okhla, Shamli, Tapri, Jind, Jakhhal, Tohana, Mansa, Narwana, Bagpat Road, Khekra, Nangoli, Muradnagar, Khatauli, Meerut Cantt, Julana, Sampla, Shivaji Bridge, Tilak Bridge, Ganaur, Tughlakabad, Faridabad New Town, Ballabgarh, Palam, Delhi Safadarganj, Partapur & Sakoti Tanda Railway Station registration fee will be charged @ rate of **Rs. 1000** for each spell of thirty days.

• **The following are the eligibility criteria for participant viz.**

a) Holder of Artisans/Weaver ID card issued by Development Commissioner Handicraft, Development Commissioner Handloom, or by the requisite state/Central Government Authority.

b) Individual artisans/weavers/craftsmen enrolled/registered with Tribal Cooperative Marketing Development Federation of India Limited (TRIFED)/National Handloom Development Corporation (NHDC)/Khadi/ Village Industries Commission (VIC)/ associated with Social Organizations, State Govt. bodies and associated with registered micro enterprises on the Udyam Portal of the Ministry of MSME and NGOs etc.

c) Self Help Groups registered with PMEGP (Prime Minister's Employment Generation Programme).

d) Marginalized or weaker sections of society.

e) No separate logo shall be allowed.

• The applicant will have to submit an undertaking to the Station Superintendent indicating that no activity would be undertaken to adversely affect the train operations, passenger safety and image of the Railways.

• Applications should be addressed and can be submitted to Station Superintendent at station by the applicant till **15:00 hrs of 08.07.2026**, which will be opened on same day.

• Station Superintendent will make priority roster of all approved participants and priority will be established through a draw of lots conducted at the station in the presence of all approved applicants by the Station Manager/Sectional CMI and nominated Finance representative.

• The 'One Station One Product' scheme shall be governed by Railway Board's Commercial Circular No. 12 of 2022 and 09 of 2023 respectively available at website: www.indianrailways.gov.in & **URL: https://indianrailways.gov.in/railwayboard/uploads/directorate/traffic_comm/Comm.Cir.2022_OSOP%20Policy.pdf & https://indianrailways.gov.in/railwayboard/uploads/directorate/traffic_comm/mCir2023/CC%20%2009%20of%202023.pdf**. For any queries applicant may contact Station Superintendent or CMI of the respective Stations. 2193/2026

SERVING CUSTOMERS WITH A SMILE

NORTHERN RAILWAY

Tender Notice NO. 23/2026-2027 Dated: 25/06/2026

Invitation of Tenders through E-Procurement system.

Principal Chief Materials Manager, Northern Railway, New Delhi-110001, for and on behalf of the President of India, invites e-tenders through e-procurement system for supply of the following items:-

S. No.	Tender No.	Brief Description	Qty.	Closing Date
01	16265010	POWERLINE SET	2 SET	21-07-26
02	16265003	FORWARD-REVERSE TURBO	1 NOS	22-07-26
03	10260037	FIRE RETARDANT CURTAIN FABRIC (BROWN COLOUR)	16584 METER	22-07-26
04	19260742	FIRE DETECTION EQUIPMENT ALONG WITH CONNECTOR	38 NOS	23-07-26
05	16263690	LOW MAINTENANCE LEAD ACID BATTERY	589 NOS	28-07-26
06	07260201	BALL JOINT TRACTION LEVER	13119 NOS	28-07-26
07	08265160	[BPAC]	10 NOS	04-08-26
08	09263322	SIDE BUFFER CASING	1283 NOS	10-08-26
09	09262506	INNER SPRING	9709 NOS	07-09-26
10	09262573	DRAFT GEAR ARRANGEMENT INCLUDING DRAFT GEAR FOLLOWER	296 NOS	14-09-26

NOTE - 1. Vendors may visit the IREPS website i.e. www.ireps.gov.in for details.
2. No Manual offer will be entertained. 2198/2026

SERVING CUSTOMERS WITH A SMILE

NORTHERN RAILWAY

E-TENDER NOTICE

Sr. Divisional Electrical Engineer/Traction Distribution, DRM's Office, State Entry Road, New Delhi for & on behalf of President of India, invites open e-tender for the under noted work:

1	Name of Work with its location :	Part-C: Relocation of leaning masts and re-profiling at curve locations in DIK section inconnection with Improvement of sectioning and feeding arrangement by shifting of insulated overlaps, Provision of separate CB and re-profiling of masts at curve loc.
2	Approx. Cost of work :	Rs. 1,03,34,664.06/-
3	Earnest Money Deposit :	Rs. 2,06,700/-
4	E-Tender Bid Online Submission Period :	06.07.2026 (00.00 Hrs.) to 20.07.2026 (15.00 Hrs.)
5	E-Tender Bid Submission End Date & E-Tender Open Date & Time :	20.07.2026 (15.00 hrs.)
6	Fund Allocation :	RRSK (PH-36)
7	Website particulars where complete details of tender documents can be seen :	www.ireps.gov.in

No.: 13-TRD-NDLS-2026-27 Dated: 25.06.2026 2200/2026

SERVING CUSTOMERS WITH A SMILE

NORTHERN RAILWAY

TENDER NOTICE

Invitation of Tender Through E-Tendering (e-Procurement Systems)

On behalf of President of India Dy. Chief Mechanical Engineer, Office at: Rail Coach Naveenikaran Karkhana Sonipat invites e-tender for below mentioned work:-

NIT No.	22-RCNK-OPN-WSEE-2026
Name of work and its location	Repair and Modification of Wheel Set Earthing Equipments of LHB Bogies at RCNK/SNP for a period of One Year (As per Scope of Work).
Approx. cost of work	*44,44,697.40 including GST@18% (Rs. Forty Four Lakh Forty Four Thousand Six Hundred Ninety Seven and Forty Paise Only)
Earnest Money	₹88,900/-
Completion Period of work	12 months (01 Year) from date of issue of Letter of acceptance.
Cost of Tender Document (in ₹)	Nil
Date and Time for submission of tender and opening of tender	Upto 15:00 hrs. on 20.07.2026 Opening of tender at 15:30 hrs. on same day
Website particulars notice board location complete details of tender can be seen	Above tender available on IREPS website i.e. www.ireps.gov.in

Tender No.: 22-RCNK-OPN-WSEE-2026 Dated : 25.06.2026 2217/2026

SERVING CUSTOMERS WITH A SMILE

Durand Cup from July 25

NEW DELHI: The upcoming edition of the Durand Cup, Asia's oldest football tournament spanning 138 years, will begin from July 25 with the final scheduled for August 23, the organisers said on Thursday.

The tournament will feature 24 teams, including two foreign sides, with matches held across five cities -- Kolkata, Ranchi, Guwahati, Imphal and Shillong, with Ranchi making its debut as a host city in the history.

	Approx. Cost of work	Rs. 2,89,57,519.58/-
	Earnest Money Deposit	Rs. 5,79,200/-
	E-Tender Bid Online Submission Period	06.07.2026 (00.00 Hrs.) to 20.07.2026 (15.00 Hrs.)
	E-Tender Bid Submission End Date & E-Tender Open Date & Time	20.07.2026 (15.00 hrs.)
	Fund Allocation	RRSK (PH-36)
	Website particulars where complete details of tender documents can be seen	www.ireps.gov.in

SERVING CUSTOMERS WITH A SMILE

कार्यपालक अभियंता का कार्यालय ग्रामीण कार्य विभाग, कार्य प्रमण्डल, गोड्डा

ई-निविदा आमंत्रण सूचना (प्रथम कॉल)

ई0-निविदा संख्या:- 01/2026-27/RWD/EE/GODDA दिनांक:-25-06-2026

कार्य का विवरण:- मुख्यमंत्री ग्राम सड़क योजना अन्तर्गत कार्यपालक अभियंता, ग्रामीण कार्य विभाग, कार्य प्रमण्डल, गोड्डा, द्वारा निम्न विवरण के अनुसार e-procurement पद्धति से निविदा आमंत्रित की जाती है।

क्रम सं.	आइटेनी फिफेसन संख्या/ पैकेज संख्या	प्रवर्ध	कार्य का नाम	प्राक्कलित राशि (लाख में)	अंश में	कार्य समाप्ति की तिथि/ अवधि
1	RWD/EE/GODDA/ 01/2026-27	महागामा	दुर्गापुर से करकटडीह तक पथ निर्माण कार्य। (लंबा-1.050कि०मी०)	99.35900	निमान्ये लाख बीस हजार नौ सौ रुपये मात्र	09 माह
2	RWD/EE/GODDA/ 02/2026-27	महागामा	गौरगामा से शीलत तक पथ निर्माण कार्य। (लंबा-1.500कि०मी०)	226.01000	दो करोड़ छब्बीस लाख एक हजार रुपये मात्र	12 माह
3	RWD/EE/GODDA/ 03/2026-27	लकुलंगटी	पीराम्पोजी(लकुलंगटी) पथ से मड़मुनाल पहाड़पुर तक सड़क निर्माण कार्य। (लंबा-1.180कि०मी०)	125.51900	एक करोड़ पच्चीस लाख इकानवन हजार नौ सौ रुपये मात्र	12 माह
4	RWD/EE/GODDA/ 04/2026-27	लकुलंगटी	पीराम्पोजी(लकुलंगटी) पथ से सिंघाईक तक सड़क निर्माण कार्य। (लंबा-1.500कि०मी०)	125.36600	एक करोड़ पच्चीस लाख छत्तीस हजार छ सौ रुपये मात्र	12 माह
5	RWD/EE/GODDA/ 05/2026-27	लकुलंगटी	देवनरक से सिलारु माया मोरामनक तक सड़क निर्माण कार्य। (लंबा-2.000कि०मी०)	231.60900	दो करोड़ इक्कीस लाख साठ हजार नौ सौ रुपये मात्र	12 माह
6	RWD/EE/GODDA/ 06/2026-27	मेहरमा	घोरीरु से सोलिनर माया लकड़मारा तक सड़क निर्माण कार्य। (लंबा-4.015कि०मी०)	476.57300	चार करोड़ छीसतल लाख सैंतान हजार तीन सौ रुपये मात्र	15 माह

1.वेबसाइट में निविदा प्रकाशन की तिथि:- 08.07.2026
2.ई-निविदा प्राप्त की अंतिम तिथि एवं समय:- 30.07.2026 अपराह्न 5:00 बजे तक।
3.निविदा खोलने की तिथि एवं समय:- 01.08.2026 पूर्वाह्न 11:30 बजे।
4.निविदा आमंत्रित करने वाले पदाधिकारी का नाम एवं पता:- कार्यपालक अभियंता, ग्रामीण कार्य विभाग, कार्य प्रमण्डल, गोड्डा।
5.ई- निविदा प्रकोष्ठ का मोबाईल नं०:- 7004195091
6.परिमाण विपन्न की राशि घट-बढ़ सकती है तदनुसार अग्रधन की राशि देय होगी।
7.निविदा शुल्क एवं अग्रधन की राशि केवल **Online Mode** द्वारा स्वीकार्य होगी।
8.निविदा शुल्क एवं अग्रधन की राशि का ई-शुल्क भुगतान जिस खाता से किया जायेगा, उसी खाते में अग्रधन की राशि वापस होगी। अगर खाता को बंद कर दिया जाता है तो उसकी सारी जवाबदेही आपकी होगी।
विरस्तुत जानकारी के लिए वेबसाइट jharkhandtenders.gov.in में देखा जा सकता है।

कार्यपालक अभियंता
ग्रामीण कार्य विभाग कार्य प्रमण्डल, गोड्डा

PR 383241 (Rural Work Department)26-27*D

Sudharsan ton powers India A march

GALLE: A fluent century from Sai Sudharsan and unbeaten fifties from skipper Dhruv Jurel and Shaik Rasheed put the India A firmly in control at 333 for four on the opening day of the unofficial Test series against Sri Lanka A here on Thursday.

Electing to bat, India A piled up big score at stumps, with Sudharsan laying the foundation with a classy 132 before skipper Jurel (68 not out) and Rasheed (53 not out) carried the momentum forward with a strong unbeaten partnership in the third and final session of play. Opening the innings, Sudharsan looked in complete command from the outset, displaying his range of strokes and sound temperament to tackle the Sri Lankan attack. AGENCIES



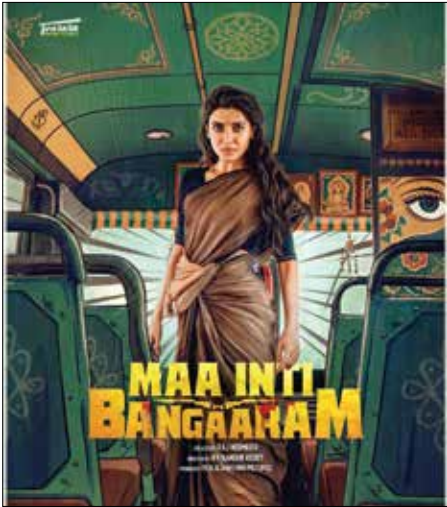
Samantha Ruth Prabhu confirms pregnancy

The actress celebrated the success of her new movie ‘Maa Inti Bangaaram’

Samantha Ruth Prabhu, who confirmed that she is expecting her first child with husband Raj Nidimoru, said she will soon take a break from acting. The actress very recently celebrated the success of her new movie ‘Maa Inti Bangaaram’, an action drama from filmmaker Nandini Reddy. The movie, which was released last week, has received unanimous praise from the critics and earned over Rs 50 crores at the global box office. “After ‘Maa Inti Bangaaram’, I will have to take a small break, given my condition. I’ll have to take maternity leave. After that, I’ll be back with another film for my fans,” Samantha told reporters.

Her announcement put an end to days of speculation about her pregnancy after some social media users claimed she appeared to have a baby bump during the film’s promotional events. The actress married filmmaker Raj Nidimoru in December 2025 in an intimate ceremony at Sadhguru’s Isha Foundation in Coimbatore. Samantha was married to actor Naga Chaitanya from 2017 to 2021, while Raj was previously married to Shhyamali De.

At the event, Samantha also reflected on relationships, saying they require equal effort from both partners. “Sometimes relationships are complicated and it isn’t always in your control. It takes two people to make a relationship work. The first, most important



At the event, she also reflected on relationships, saying they require equal effort from both partners

thing for a woman to do is to have confidence in herself, to be complete as a person. Then you will find the right person. If you look for someone else to complete you and feel incomplete while waiting for that person, mistakes will happen because there will be more expectations from the other person. That isn’t right. Be complete first and then get into a relationship. That usually works out,” she said.

‘Maa Inti Bangaaram’ marks Samantha’s reunion with the filmmaker after their 2019 hit ‘Oh! Baby’. The screenplay is written by Raj Nidimoru and Vasanth Maringanti. The film also stars Gulshan Devaiah, Diganth Manchale, Gautami Tadimalla, Sreemukhi, Manjusha and Srinivas Gavireddy in pivotal roles.

‘Slowly finding my way back’

Popular playback singer Alka Yagnik on her health struggles

Popular playback singer Alka Yagnik, who had been diagnosed with hearing loss in 2024 and was in the capital to receive the Padma Bhushan, said she is slowly finding her way back after stepping away from the spotlight to deal with her health issues.

The ‘Agar Tum Saath Ho’ and ‘Ek Do Teen’ singer received the honour from President Droupadi Murmu at the Rashtrapati Bhavan on Tuesday. Seen in public for the first time in a long time, she looked frail and walked with the help of an attendant.



The ‘Agar Tum Saath Ho’ and ‘Ek Do Teen’ singer received the Padma Shri honour on Tuesday

A day later, the 60-year-old opened her heart in a lengthy ‘Instagram’ post, revealing that she had suffered sensorineural nerve hearing loss caused by a viral attack two years ago. It is a hearing disorder that happens when there is damage to tiny hair cells within the inner ear or the auditory nerve that transmits sound signals to the brain. Causes can include genetics, ageing and sudden exposure to loud noise and viral fevers.

“For the last two years, I have stayed away from the spotlight, from public appearances and from sharing much of my journey. Many of you know I

am going through difficult health and through it all, your love, prayers, messages and unwavering support have stayed with me every step of the way. Today, as I stepped out to receive one of the highest civilian honours in the country - the distinguished Padma Bhushan, I did so with a heart full of gratitude,” she wrote.

Yagnik, one of Bollywood’s most successful singers, said she is deeply humbled by the honour. “While my name may be on it, it belongs just as much to every listener who welcomed my voice into their lives, carried my songs through generations and stood by me through both the highs and the challenges. This moment feels especially meaningful because it marks not just a recognition of my work, but a reminder of the strength that comes from love, hope and resilience... I am slowly finding my way back.”

Vishal Bhardwaj & others among 529 new invites for Academy membership

Director-composer Vishal Bhardwaj, film editors Deepa Bhatia and A Sreekar Prasad, as well as costume designer Eka Lakhani and casting director Dilip Shankar, are among the 529 artists invited by the Academy of Motion Picture Arts and Sciences to become its members.

“We are delighted to invite this remarkable group of film artists and professionals from around the world to join the Academy. Through their commitment to filmmaking, this year’s exceptionally talented class has made significant contributions to our global movie industry,” Academy CEO Bill Kramer and Academy President Lynette Howell Taylor said.

Bhardwaj, who started his cinema journey as a music composer before branching out as a successful filmmaker, has been invited as a composer to join the organisation. The filmmaker has always composed music for his films, be it ‘Maqbool’, ‘Omkaara’, ‘Kaminey’ and ‘Haider’. He has also given music to Gulzar’s ‘Maachis’ and most recently composed



for Manish Malhotra’s production ‘Gustaakh Ishq’.

In its release, the Academy said the membership process for its 19 branches and one membership classification is conducted by sponsorship, not application. Additionally, Academy Award nominees are automatically considered for membership in the year in which they are nominated and do not require sponsors.

Membership selection is based on professional qualifications, with an ongoing commitment to representation, inclusion and equity remaining a priority. Of the 2026 invited class, 42 per cent are women, 56 per cent belong to under-represented communities and 53 per cent are from 60 countries and territories outside the United States.

ANURAG KASHYAP ON ‘LAGAAN’ ‘Wasseypur... wouldn’t be possible without Lagaan’

Filmmaker Anurag Kashyap said ‘Lagaan’ and its making taught the industry a lot and made it possible for him to explore a two-part story like ‘Gangs of Wasseypur’.

‘Lagaan’, directed by Ashutosh Gowariker and starring Aamir Khan and a host of supporting actors from the theatre, completed 25 years of its release on June 15. Despite its run of over three hours and 40 minutes, the film emerged as a major hit and was even nominated in the ‘Best Foreign Language’ category at the 74th Academy Awards.

In a video shared by ‘Aamir Khan Productions’, Kashyap recounted how excited he and his group of new filmmakers were to see ‘Lagaan’ in theatres when it released.

“It was the first film that had that kind of an impact in a very long time. If ‘Lagaan’ had not worked, then we as filmmakers would not have been able to make films like ‘Wasseypur’ and all. That kind of duration, length, like if you hold on to the story of the film, you don’t feel like it’s three hours and 40 minutes. Today, the industry that we are working in is like the



Filmmaker Anurag Kashyap said ‘Lagaan’ and its making taught the industry a lot

children of ‘Lagaan’ in a way,” Kashyap said in the video.

Kashyap later directed ‘Gangs of Wasseypur’ and ‘Gangs of Wasseypur 2’, which were released in 2012. The films featured raw dialogue, anti-heroes without redemption arcs, regional folk music, and a narrative spanning three generations of coal mafia feuds.

Kashyap recalled the euphoric moment of watching ‘Lagaan’ unfold on the big screen.

‘The world of Ab Hoga Hisaab has a certain density to it’

Mouni Roy stars alongside Sanjay Kapoor, Shaheer and others in Amazon MX Player’s series

OUR CORRESPONDENT

Amazon MX Player recently launched ‘Ab Hoga Hisaab’, a gripping revenge drama set against the vivid backdrop of Punjab. The series follows brothers Bobby and Bunty Manocha, whose lives are irrevocably altered by a single, fateful incident. Rooted in themes of brotherhood, loyalty and sacrifice, the show delves into the lengths one can go for family and the price that often comes with it.

The web series is led by Sanjay Kapoor and Shaheer, alongside a stellar ensemble cast including Mouni Roy, Avinash Mishra, Nimrit Kaur Ahluwalia, Harman Singha and Aasheema Vardaan in pivotal roles.

Reflecting on her experience of working with the ensemble cast and the bonds forged during filming, Mouni shared, “The entire team became family faster than I expected. Nimrit and I really connected off camera. We’d end up chatting between shots about everything except the scene we’d just done, which I think is always a good sign. Shaheer’s calm energy made every day on set feel easy. By the end, it felt less like a shoot and more like a family. Working with Sanjay sir was a masterclass in itself. He has an incredible presence, but what stayed with me most was his stillness. He trusts silence, trusts the moment. Watching that discipline unfold close was a learning experience in itself.”

Opening up about stepping into the layered and unpredictable world of the series, she added, “The world of ‘Ab Hoga Hisaab’ has a certain density to it. Everyone is hiding something, everyone has a reason and nothing is as black and white as it appears. It keeps viewers guessing and constantly questioning who they should trust and where everyone’s loyalties truly lie. That’s exactly the kind of space I love working in as an actor. Watching it all come together on screen, seeing the world we built piece by piece on set finally take on a life of its own, is always the most exciting part for me. Seeing the final result unfold so beautifully makes the entire journey worthwhile.”

‘The entire team became family faster than I expected,’ she says



‘Haven’t really done as much’

Priyanka compared her Bollywood career to Hollywood

Priyanka Chopra Jonas is steadily building an international career across film and television. Her global credits include titles such as ‘Baywatch’, ‘The Matrix Resurrections’ and the recently released ‘The Bluff’, along with headlining series like ‘Quantico’ and ‘Citadel’. However, speaking at the ‘Cannes Lions’ conference on Wednesday, the actress said she still feels her most defining work in the English-language space is ahead of her and that she is looking to push her career into its next phase.

“In my Hindi-language career, I’ve worked with all the best filmmakers and the best

She opened up about how marriage & motherhood have reshaped her priorities

actors. I’ve told amazing stories and done a variety of genres. Whereas in America, in Hollywood, in my English-language work, I haven’t really done that as much,” said Chopra. She also said her next reinvention would focus on finding ways, in her English-language career, to replicate the range and diversity of characters she has already explored in Indian cinema.

On a personal note, she opened up about how marriage and motherhood have reshaped her priorities, admitting that her ‘life has changed tremendously’. She said, “Your priorities really change. I don’t just pack my bags and go off for a movie anymore. I don’t do five films a year. I don’t travel the way I used to. I’m really, really selective about the time I spend and who I spend it with... I’m navigating working-mom life. I have so much more respect for my mother now.”

A few months earlier, Priyanka had also spoken about her decision to step away from Bollywood at the height of her career.

AGENCIES